



PUBLIC AWARENESS — KNOW WHAT THE HIGH COURT ACTUALLY SAID

“ONE OF THE BIGGEST SCAMS IN THE STATE OF KARNATAKA”

THE NICE ROAD / BMICP TOLL PROJECT — IN THE KARNATAKA
HIGH COURT'S OWN WORDS

Karnataka High Court, Division Bench judgment dated
29.07.2026 — W.A. No.1214/2025 & connected matters



SCAN FOR HC OBSERVATIONS



5 / 111 km
Expressway built in
25–26 years



20,193 Acres
of farmers' land acquired
for the project



554 Acres
of “excess” land
admittedly
handed to NICE



20,000+ Acres
land bank NICE
now sits on



THE JUDICIAL VERDICT: HIGH COURT FINDINGS

The Hon'ble High Court of Karnataka has observed
that the Bengaluru-Mysuru Infrastructure Corridor
(BMIC) project “appears to be one of the biggest
scams in Karnataka”.



THE CONTRACT VIOLATIONS: LEGISLATIVE REPORT

In December 2016, an 11-member Legislative House Committee
headed by Shri T.B. Jayachandra submitted a comprehensive 391-page
report confirming extensive contractual, financial, and environmental
violations by NICE.



UNAUTHORIZED REAL ESTATE HANDOUTS (110 ACRES)

NICE executed secretive sale deeds, agreements, and Joint
Development Agreements (JDAs) with private real estate
developers, transferring approximately 110 acres of acquired
public land worth hundreds of crores without transparency:

- Umang Realtech Pvt Ltd • Dhammanagi Developers
- SBK Properties Pvt Ltd • Ajmera Housing Corp. • Darshita Housing Pvt Ltd
- 2,472 Acres Reallocated: Land earmarked for five townships under the Outline Development Plan was quietly reallocated to road components without satisfactory documentation.
- **Environmental Damage:** Precious lake-beds and water bodies were illegally transferred to NICE, causing severe environmental degradation and impacting Bengaluru's water supply.

HOUSE COMMITTEE RECOMMENDATIONS FOR RECOVERY

- Return 11,060 Acres of Excess Land: Exclude 7,532 acres of private land and 3,528 acres of government land acquired illegally, and return it to original owners.
- Recover 242.45 Crore Penalty: Formally recover unpaid mining royalty and penalties from NICE for illegal mining.
- High-Level National Investigation: Order immediate probes by the CBI,

1. ACQUIRED FOR THE PUBLIC. MONETISED FOR PRIVATE GAIN. 2. PUBLIC PURPOSE OR PRIVATE PROFIT? 3. ACQUISITION BECOMES COMMERCIALISATION.

DEMANDS TO THE STATE GOVERNMENT BY TAX PAYERS

1. Take over the Bengaluru–Mysuru Infrastructure Corridor Project (BMICP) / NICE Road project with immediate effect;
2. Stop, with immediate effect, all toll collection by NICE on the Expressway, Peripheral Road and Link Road;
3. Constitute an independent special team of experts to conduct a comprehensive forensic audit of NICE's accounts and operations, as recommended by the Hon'ble High Court, and publish the report and action taken thereon;
4. Take appropriate departmental and, where warranted, criminal action against officials found complicit in the violations recorded by the High Court;
5. Restore and protect the lakes, tanks and tank-bed lands transferred to NICE, and take steps to remedy the resulting damage to Bengaluru's ecology and water supply;
6. Ensure that the affected farmers and landowners are paid fair and prompt compensation in accordance with Article 300A of the Constitution of India and applicable law

STATEMENT BY

SHRI H.D. KUMARASWAMY

State President, Janata Dal (Secular), Karnataka

The State High Court has made a strong observation that the NICE BMIC project appears to be one of the biggest scams in the state. Therefore, the State Government must take over the entire project. Vehicle users should not pay toll charges while travelling on the NICE Road from now on.

**WE, THE PUBLIC, DEMAND: STOP THE TOLL, NOW • TAKE OVER THE PROJECT
• ORDER THE FORENSIC AUDIT THE COURT ITSELF ASKED FOR**

Source: Karnataka High Court, judgment dated 29.07.2026 in W.A. No.1214/2025 and connected Writ Appeals



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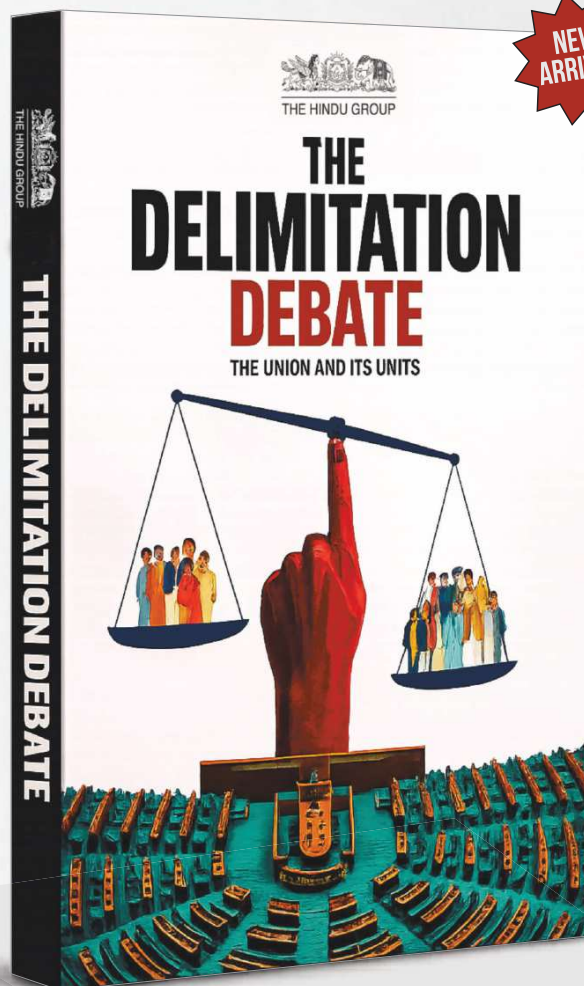
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SUSTAINABLE HABITAT

Making an asset out of a botanical liability

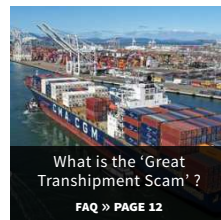
Conservation project aims at reclaiming Assam's elephant habitat, one weed at a time

NEWS » PAGE 9



Retractions alone don't correct research issues

SCIENCE » PAGE 11



What is the 'Great Transshipment Scam'?

FAQ » PAGE 12



India holds the edge in Colombo Test

SPORT » PAGE 15

IN BRIEF



Centre sets up panel to resolve Gorkha issue

KOLKATA
The Centre on Saturday decided to set up a committee to draft an agreement for a "permanent political solution" to the demands of the Gorkha community in the Darjeeling hills and adjoining areas of north Bengal. » [Page 7](#)

Be loud and fight for your space, Rahul tells Gen Z

PUNE
In his fourth 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' address held in Pune on Saturday, senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi asked Gen Z girls to "be loud, be proud and fight for your space in the society". » [Page 8](#)

CLASSIFIEDS » PAGE 6
MAGAZINE » 8 PAGES

Cong. alleges bulk voter purge bid in Uttarakhand

Opposition party raises the issue with the EC, says several individuals have submitted thousands of Form 7 applications for deletion of voters from electoral rolls under the ongoing SIR in the State

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Congress leaders in Uttarakhand have alleged that the Election Commission (EC) is accepting and processing unverified bulk applications to delete voters' names during the claims and objections period of the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of voter lists in the State.

The party submitted a memorandum to the poll body in Delhi on Thursday, complaining that certain individuals have each submitted thousands of Form 7 applications. A party delegation subsequently met Uttarakhand's Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), B.V.R.C. Purushottam, in Dehradun on Friday to raise their concerns.

Claims and objections

The booth-level officer or the Electoral Registration Officer has to conduct an inquiry into each Form 7 application and issue a notice to the voter before taking any action

■ Form 7 is filed to object to an existing name on the electoral rolls or to request the deletion of a name due to reasons such as death, migration, or ineligibility

■ Most of the people linked to similar cases of bulk Form 7 submissions in Rajasthan, Gujarat, and Assam had denied having anything to do with them



Verification wait: More than 8 lakh voters have been removed from the draft electoral roll for Uttarakhand under the ongoing SIR phase 3. FILE PHOTO

A Form 7 is filed to object to an existing name on the electoral rolls or to request the deletion of a name due to reasons such as death, migration, or ineligibility. The booth-level officer (BLO) or the Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) has to conduct an inquiry into each Form 7 application and issue a notice to the voter before taking any action. As *The Hindu* had earlier reported, cases of bulk Form 7 submissions had previously surfaced in States such as Rajasthan, Gujarat, and Assam. Most of the people in whose

quity into each Form 7 application and issue a notice to the voter before taking any action. As *The Hindu* had earlier reported, cases of bulk Form 7 submissions had previously surfaced in States such as Rajasthan, Gujarat, and Assam. Most of the people in whose

names the forms had been filed had denied that they had anything to do with them.

While booth-level agents of political parties are allowed to file maximum 10 Form 7 a day and only 30 in total, there is no limit on how many such forms an individual elector can submit. The Congress, citing data from the Uttarakhand CEO, said that, from the date of voter list draft publication up to August 6, a total of 262 individual objectors had each filed more than 10 Form 7, adding up to several thousands. Mr. Purushottam told *The Hindu* that he would look into all allegations of bulk Form 7 submissions in the State.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 7

Pressure mounts on BCI chief amid demands for resignation

Soibam Rocky Singh
NEW DELHI

Pressure on incumbent Bar Council of India (BCI) chairperson Manan Kumar Mishra mounted on Saturday with a demand for his resignation being formally raised during a meeting of the BCI General Council at its office in New Delhi.

BCI member Manoj Kumar Narendran from Kerala called for Mr. Mishra's resignation during the meeting, placing the demand directly before the General Council. His call was supported by another member from Uttar Pradesh, advocate Srinath Tripathi.

Mr. Narendran told *The Hindu* that the chairperson did not accept the demand and that the next course of action would be decided later.

He said that the functioning of the BCI had, over the years, increasingly come to be identified with the authority and deci-



Manan Kumar Mishra

sions of its chairperson rather than the collective will of the council.

Concerning moves

"Of particular concern is the amendment by which the tenure of the chairperson was extended to five years. Serious questions arise regarding the legality of such an amendment and the manner in which it was brought about, particularly when its effect was to directly benefit the incumbent chairperson by enabling a substantially longer continuance in office," Mr. Narendran said.

The demand at the General Council meeting came on the heels of a letter by BCI co-chairperson Y.R. Sasidasa Reddy, who called upon Mr. Mishra to step down and sought an independent probe into a series of allegations concerning the functioning and financial administration of the statutory body.

On Thursday, more than 200 lawyers gathered outside the BCI office under the banner of the All India Young Advocates Association, raising demands including reforms in the BCI's election mechanism and greater accountability in its functioning.

On Friday, a plea was filed in the Supreme Court challenging the legality of Mr. Mishra's prolonged tenure as BCI chairperson. The plea has not been listed for hearing yet.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 7
SEVERAL ALLEGATIONS
» PAGE 7

Rowing to glory



Team effort: The 'Aroma Chundan' (number 10), rowed by the Aroma Boat Club, finishes first at the 72nd Nehru Trophy Boat Race on Punnamada Lake in Alappuzha, Kerala, on Saturday. SURESH ALLEPPEY

Centre expands curbs on cold medicines for children under 4

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The Union Health Ministry has imposed restrictions on the manufacture, sale, and distribution of all fixed-dose combinations (FDCs) containing chlorpheniramine maleate and phenylephrine hydrochloride, mandating a clear warning that these medicines shall not be used to treat children below four years of age.

Last year, the Centre restricted certain FDCs containing the two ingredients, subject to the same age-specific warning. The latest notification extends the requirement to all formulations containing these two ingredients. The decision follows recommendations of an expert committee and the Drugs Technical Advisory Board. The move comes amid tightened scrutiny of

Risk alleviation

The government has noted that the use of the barred ingredients may pose risks to children below four years of age



■ Young children are particularly vulnerable to dosing errors and adverse effects from multi-ingredient medicines

Chlorpheniramine maleate:

■ Antihistamine used to reduce symptoms of cold

■ It can cause drowsiness or, paradoxically, excitability

Phenylephrine hydrochloride:

■ A decongestant intended to relieve nasal blockage

■ It can affect heart rate and blood pressure

cough-and-cold medicines in young children. The combination of chlorpheniramine maleate, an antihistamine used to reduce symptoms such as a runny nose and sneezing, and phenylephrine hydrochloride, a decongestant intended to relieve nasal blockage, has long been used in cold and allergy preparations. Young chil-

dren are particularly vulnerable to dosing errors and adverse effects from multi-ingredient medicines. Chlorpheniramine can cause marked drowsiness or, paradoxically, excitability, while phenylephrine can affect heart rate and blood pressure.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 7

CJP, Jaipur villagers lodge cross FIRs day after school visit incident

The Hindu Bureau
JAIPUR

A day after members of the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) were allegedly attacked during a visit to the Government Primary School in Jaipur's Rampura-Kanwarapura village, the outfit and local villagers lodged FIRs on Saturday accusing one another of assault and creating disturbance.

A CJP team had reached the village on Friday to inspect the condition of the school when a confrontation broke out between its members and local residents. Shivdaspura Station House Officer Rajesh Gautam said a local villager lodged a complaint on Friday night, alleging that children were frightened and stopped attending school after the incident.

Mr. Gautam said the second FIR was registered on the basis of a complaint by a CJP member, who alleged that members of the team had been assaulted during the incident.

'Attack by BJP goons'

Reacting to the FIR, CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka alleged that the attackers were "goons" called by Bharatiya Janata Party leaders. "We have videos and all the evidence. If they also have evidence, let them show it," he said.

About 20 students turned up for classes as an uneasy calm prevailed in the village on Saturday. The students were shifted to a vacant house. Until then, they were attending classes in a cattle enclosure after the school building was declared unsafe.

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States

Job aspirants
detained after
scuffle with
police in Patna**Press Trust of India**
PATNA

Several job aspirants were detained on Saturday after a scuffle with police during a march to Lok Bhavan in Patna to press for a transparent recruitment process, officials said. A large number of job aspirants participated in the march, which was stopped near R-Golumber where barricades were put up, they said.

A scuffle broke out as the protesters tried to breach the barricades, following which the security personnel used "mild force" to disperse them. Many protesters were subsequently detained, they added. City SP (Central) Mamta Kalyani said, "Adequate forces have been deployed."

Delhi
DELHI**SUNDAY, AUG. 23**
RISE 05:55 SET 18:53
RISE 15:51 SET 01:05**MONDAY, AUG. 24**
RISE 05:55 SET 18:52
RISE 16:35 SET 02:00**TUESDAY, AUG. 25**
RISE 05:56 SET 18:51
RISE 17:16 SET 02:57**Delhi Weather** max min
Delhi City 35 25
Safdarjung 35 25
Palam 34 24**Delhi Palam Today**
35°C The weather will be warm with uneasy afternoon. Night will be comfortable. Spell of light rain and thundershower with gusty winds to occur.**Delhi Palam Tomorrow**
35°C The weather will be warm with uneasy afternoon. Night will be comfortable. Spell of light to moderate rain and thundershower to occur.
© Copyright Siptel Weather 2026
All rights reserved.M.P. CM asks officials to visit families
affected by Ken-Betwa river project

Hear their grievances sensitively, understand actual situation, says Mohan Yadav; directive comes just days after Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi met some protesters who have been demanding better compensation and rehabilitation for the families

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav has directed officials to visit the villages in Panna and Chhatarpur districts and meet the families impacted by the Ken-Betwa river link project to hear their grievances.

Mr. Yadav issued the directions after holding a review meeting for the project in Khajuraho on Friday.

The move comes just days after Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi met a group of protesters who had staged demonstrations in April and July demanding better compensation and rehabilitation for the families af-



Tribal families affected by the Ken-Betwa project during a protest in Chhatarpur. FILE PHOTO

ected by the Centre's ₹44,000-crore Ken-Betwa Link Project (KBLP) and five State government works including the Majhgaon and Runjh irrigation projects.

Mr. Yadav directed the Panna and Chhatarpur district administrations to ensure that officials visit every household in the affected villages to understand the actual situation

and problems of the families. He directed the officials to listen sensitively to the difficulties faced by the tribal families and resolve them on priority, a government statement said after the review meeting.

Delivery of benefits
Mr. Yadav also asked officials to ensure doorstep delivery of benefits of various government welfare

schemes are reaching the eligible families that have been displaced due to the project. "He said where families have settled at new locations, concrete action plans should be prepared to provide essential facilities such as schools, anganwadi centres, health centres and community halls," the statement said.

In April and July, hundreds of tribals from villages in the two districts had staged 'satyagrah' protests in various forms, including by standing in water and lying on symbolic pyres on the banks of Barana river in Chhatarpur against the project.

The demonstrations ended on July 19 after the State police dismantled the protest site and forcibly admitted activist Amit Bhat-

nagar, who had been on a hunger strike, to a hospital.

Mr. Yadav also instructed officials to ensure early payment of the approved additional amount to those affected by the Runjh and Majhgaon projects in Panna. The compensation for the two projects was increased from ₹5 lakh to ₹12.5 lakh for each affected family.

Earlier on August 19, Mr. Gandhi extended support to the affected villages after meeting Mr. Bhatnagar and other protesters, and said that he would visit the area. "The problems, demands, struggles, and personal ordeals of the tribal brothers and sisters... In this fight, I and the Congress stand with them," he had written on X, sharing a video from the meeting.

YouTuber who reported
Ram Temple donation
theft claims harassment**The Hindu Bureau**
NEW DELHI

Abhishek Upadhyay, who runs a YouTube news channel that reported the theft of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, has alleged harassment over his reports on corruption and other irregularities in Uttar Pradesh.

'FIR copy not given'

In a series of posts on X, Mr. Upadhyay has alleged that a fresh case had been registered against him and a copy of the First Information Report filed in Ghaziabad was not given to him.

According to Mr. Upadhyay, he was in Indrapuram when a motorcyclist approached from behind and "made contact" with his car on August 18. The man alleged that Mr. Upadhyay had hit his motorcycle, and asked the former to accompany him to the area police post, where the motorcyclist's complaint was recorded, the YouTuber said.

On August 19, Mr. Upadhyay published a report concerning allegations involving an Indian Administrative Service official and two plots of agricultural land worth several crores bought in 2023. The report alleged that a school was then constructed on the land. He alleged that the YouTube video was removed within half an hour, under provisions for bullying and harassment. Following an overnight legal challenge, he said, the video was restored on August 20. Around 10.20 p.m. on August 20, when Mr. Upadhyay was in Delhi, he received a call from his wife

informing him that some male police personnel had reached his residence in Ghaziabad.

He spoke to one of the police personnel over the phone.

Car towed away

According to Mr. Upadhyay, the in-charge told him that a case had been registered, and asked him to appear at the post. He asked for a copy of the FIR. At 2.45 a.m. on August 21, he received through WhatsApp a link to the FIR, which only had a single page, and had no details of the legal provisions invoked or the alleged incident. When he sought the entire content, he received another link, which had an FIR filed against him in Lucknow in 2025 "after he had reported the murder of a NET student" in Gorakhpur. He alleged that the police towed away his vehicle on the same day.

Mr. Upadhyay, through his X handle, has posted 10 of his stories dealing with allegations of corruption in the Uttar Pradesh Public Works Department, and illegal mining in U.P.; irregularities in an examination conducted in U.P. by a company, which was under the scanner in Jharkhand; and irregularities in the State Revenue Department.

Congress MP and the party's media and publicity department head Pawan Khera, Aam Aadmi Party's Sanjay Singh and Rashtriya Janata Dal spokesperson Priyanka Bharti have extended support to Mr. Upadhyay. "The man who came to the rescue of the faith of Indians is now being hounded," Mr. Khera said on X.

LDF members lock horns over
Dy. Leader of Opposition post**The Hindu Bureau**
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The vexing issue of which party would get the Deputy Leader of the Opposition post in the Kerala Assembly is roiling the Left Democratic Front (LDF), with Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan and Communist Party of India (CPI) State secretary Binoy Viswam locking horns over the matter on Saturday.

Mr. Vijayan told the presspersons in Thrissur

on Saturday that there was no doubt that the post of Deputy Leader of the Opposition would go to his party, the Communist Party of India (Marxist), which leads the Opposition front. He summarily ruled out any chance of the post being given to the CPI.

Mr. Vijayan said the only requirement left now was submission of a letter to the Speaker naming the Deputy Opposition leader.

Mr. Viswam told presspersons that he would not

believe Mr. Vijayan would say what he was quoted as saying. "I would humbly state that it was unbecoming of the Leader of the Opposition to have said so and that it was not in keeping with his political maturity," Mr. Viswam said.

He made it clear that the post of Deputy LoP was a contentious issue within the LDF. To a question, he said no politician or media house had the right to put a price on the CPI's self-respect.

U.P. Dy. CM meets 'quota
reform' agitators, assures
dialogue with Ministers**Mayank Kumar**
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak said in Lucknow on Saturday that the demands raised by students involved in the "reservation reform" movement would be taken up with the Central leadership of the Bharatiya Janata Party and a meeting with the Union Minister concerned would be ensured.

Mr. Pathak was addressing

a press conference with Harsh Dubey, who claims to be the leader of the reservation reform movement at Jantar Mantar.

Mr. Dubey said the students had held a peaceful protest and their main demand was that they get equal opportunities.

However, other members of the movement reportedly distanced themselves from the meeting, saying the movement is very much on.

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INBRIEF



BJP seeks CBI probe into Jharkhand recruitment exams

Union Minister Sanjay Seth on Saturday accused the Hemant Soren government of using force against students protesting alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations in Jharkhand and demanded a probe by the Central Bureau of Investigation into all recruitment exams conducted over the past six years. He alleged JMM workers assaulted protesters and students in Ranchi, Hazaribagh, Giridih and Garhwa. Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Babul Marandi sought the identification and immediate arrest of those responsible.

ED searches pastor's premises over alleged FCRA violations

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Saturday said it searched two premises in Jaipur linked to Rajasthan pastor Ravi Mohan Pahadiya on August 21 under the Foreign Exchange Management Act. The ED alleged that Mr. Pahadiya, a Protestant missionary affiliated with Hope Ministry, received ₹2.88 crore in foreign funds without FCRA (Foreign Contribution Regulation Act) registration and used them for proselytisation and conversion among SC/Valmiki and ST-Bhill communities. Of this, ₹2.34 crore was received by Mr. Pahadiya and his wife, citing consultancy and family maintenance. It alleged he used funds for personal expenses, travel and property. **PH**

Punjab Congress distances itself from MP's remarks on Sajjan Kumar's death

Press Trust of India
CHANDIGARH

Punjab Congress leaders have distanced themselves from party MP Deepender Singh Hooda's remarks describing the death of former Congress MP Sajjan Kumar as an "irreparable

loss".

Kumar, 80, who was serving two life sentences in connection with the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, died on Thursday.

Punjab Congress president Amrinder Singh Raja Warring said on Saturday that Mr. Hooda's com-

ments "may be his personal view". He said the riots were a "massive tragedy" whose wounds remain.

Jalandhar MP Charanjit Singh Channi stated on X that Kumar's death in prison was "a dark reminder of an individual who disgraced humanity and jus-

tice". He called him a "killer of the Sikh community".

Aam Aadmi Party MLA Kuldeep Singh Dhaliwal asked the Congress leadership to clarify whether Mr. Hooda's remarks represented the party's position and demanded action against him.

Maharashtra issues notices to over 700 drivers over lack of Marathi proficiency

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

Maharashtra's Transport Department has issued notices to 777 drivers found lacking a working knowledge of practical Marathi after 5,211 drivers were tested across the State, officials said on



Drivers have been given time till Sept. 30 to learn Marathi. **PTI**

Saturday.

The inspection drive,

launched on August 20 after the August 15 deadline for autorickshaw and taxi drivers to learn functional Marathi, will continue until September 30. "Strict action will be taken against those who do not follow the rules even after the given deadline," Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik

said. The Regional Transport Office has deployed marshals and officials to test drivers through everyday conversations at busy stands and junctions. Marathi proficiency is mandatory for permit renewals and new badges under the Maharashtra Motor Vehicles Rules.

SPOTLIGHT

Vanita Bhatnagar

Kajodmal Jat's solar farm is different from those surrounding it. In Kundanpura, a village in Bassi block, nearly an hour's drive east of Jaipur, Rajasthan's capital, the sight of fields dotted with rows of ground-mounted solar panels is now common. On 60-year-old Jat's land, though, tender maize unfurls under the dark glass of the panels reflecting the afternoon light. The maize fills a space that conventional solar farms leave barren.

Jat has been working with researchers of Indian Council for Research on Agricultural Biotechnology (ICRIER) on an agrophotovoltaics (APV) project. Also known as agrivoltaics or agriPV, it is a practice in which the same land is used for agriculture and solar power generation. His farm is part of a pilot, spread across nearly 3 acres. This is Rajasthan's first farmer-owned APV, which generates 600 kW. The installation feeds enough electricity into a local grid to provide day-time irrigation power for around 250 farms.

In 2023, inspired by the growing solar-panel-covered fields of his neighbours, Jat exchanged the uncertainties of each harvest for the predictability of monthly income. "My farm was generating solar power, but I could not come to terms with the fact that I was no longer able to cultivate my land because

of the solar panels," he recalls. India ranks 102nd out of 123 countries on the 2025 Global Hunger Index. Converting productive farmlands to solar power plants risks intensifying food insecurity.

APV works on the principle that partial shading from solar panels can reduce heat stress and evaporation while creating a more stable microclimate, potentially valuable for farming in dry and arid regions. Laxmi Sharma, a research associate with the ICRIER, was assigned the job of helping Jat explore the APV model. "When we showed him that he could combine farming with solar energy generation, he was delighted by the prospect," she recalls.

APV can increase farmers' annual returns by around ₹3 lakh to ₹4 lakh per acre, but elevated mounting structures add nearly ₹35 lakh over a conventional installation.

Solar entrepreneurs

Through farming Jat was able to earn close to ₹40,000 a year, but with these panels, his annual income has increased to about ₹3 lakh.

In mid-2024, a young team of researchers in New Delhi set out to study the viability of a farmer-owned agrophotovoltaics model. "When we started, there were only around two dozen agrophotovoltaics pilots in India," says Laxmi, who joined ICRIER in 2024 for this project. "Most were led by academic institutions or private developers."

In Madhya Pradesh,

Sowing the seeds of a solar power intervention

India's emerging agrophotovoltaics model enables farmers to grow crops beneath solar panels, offering a way to generate electricity while diversifying income. High upfront costs, financing constraints and uneven policy support, however, are limiting its adoption beyond pilots



Kajodmal Jat (second from left) and his family members at the 600 kW Agri-PV pilot in Kundanpura village, Bassi, Rajasthan. **SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT**

Anand Jain, an MTech graduate from IIT Roorkee and a farmer since the 1990s, had arrived at the same question from a different direction. "Because I am a farmer, I wanted to save every inch of my land," he says. The panels, he reasoned, should adapt to the farm, not force the farm out. His own experience became an early example of the kind of farmer-led model that ICRIER would later seek to study more systematically.

The ICRIER team distilled its findings in an April 2025 report titled "Solar as a Third Crop to Augment Farmers' Income." They

then set out to test this idea in the field.

Taking the risk

Jat and his family were intrigued but cautious. "We are often shown ambitious schemes and glossy promises, but when things go south, we are left to navigate the uncertainty and financial risk on our own," recalls Shiv, 36, Jat's son, who was closely involved with his father in the APV project. The researchers, meanwhile, wanted to know whether Jat was serious enough to continue cultivating the land for the next 25 years. "For us, Kajodmal was a stranger. For

Kajodmal, we were just another group of experts. Trust had to be built through multiple conversations," recalls Laxmi.

Jat and his son say that their experience with ICRIER's earlier work made the difference. The team had already been working with farmers on a net-house project, and they had seen their efforts first-hand. "They didn't just come and tell us about a plan, they were showing us what they were doing. That is what earned our trust," says Shiv.

They worked through the technical and financial details together, but if agri-

voltaics were to create farmer-entrepreneurs rather than grant recipients, Jat had to invest in the project himself and share its risks.

Trusting the process

The next challenge lay in retrofitting an operational solar plant. "A lot of individual farmers told us, 'We already have a steady source of income. If construction means losing energy revenue during that period, we're not interested,'" recalls Subhdeep Basu, a researcher at ICRIER, who worked on the 'Solar as a Third Crop...' study. Hence, they retrofitted the plant, one inverter at a time, allowing the remaining sections to continue generating electricity. "That way we could minimise this energy loss," says Basu.

The ICRIER team decided to advise farmers on which crops were most likely to thrive beneath the panels. Jat chose maize, hoping to grow it during the off season under the cooler microclimate created by the panels, when supplies were thin and prices higher. "This year, we harvested an abundant maize crop with much less water," says Shiv.

For this pilot, the additional cost of retrofitting, i.e., ₹35.3 lakh, was provided by Kotak Mahindra through their CSR programme Kotak Karma. The electricity generated by the plant would continue to flow into the grid, where Rajasthan's distribution utility, Jaipur Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd. (JVNL),

would purchase it at ₹3.14 per unit for 25 years. With viability gap funding covering part of the upfront cost, the wait to recover his investment was cut almost in half. Annual profits also increased from ₹3.76 lakh to ₹4.48 lakh per acre, while the expected return on investment rose from 12% to 18%.

The gap

GIZ India, a German development agency that funded the project, found that 54% of the 1,700 farmers it engaged through workshops expressed interest in adopting agriPV systems.

"I already have a ground-mounted solar plant. But I don't have the appetite to take such a big loan or put in that kind of money," says a farmer who had watched Jat's project evolve from its earliest days. With lending rates hovering around 10.5%, the economics remain challenging for most farmers, says Ashok Gulati, an agricultural economist and professor at ICRIER.

He also suggests that a credit guarantee backed by the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD) could make smaller agriPV projects easier to finance. But for now, no such financing window exists, a NABARD official confirmed.

Jain sees the implementation gap from the PM-KUSUM is a Central government scheme which offers incentives to farmers using solar energy but its execution is entirely at the State level. "There should be a single-

window system under the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy, so farmers are not left navigating this maze on their own."

He took more than nine months to get the power-purchase agreement done. Meters added another hidden cost. Further, the stamp duty on registered mortgage agreements for solar projects can run into lakhs. Rajasthan's energy department, however, says the process has been streamlined, with nodal officers, standardised procedures, simpler land acquisition processes and the shifting of implementation from the Rajasthan Renewable Energy Corporation to power distribution companies.

The price of possibility

Subrahmanyam Pulipaka, CEO, National Solar Energy Federation of India, says that for agriPV to move beyond pilots, India must first establish a clear definition of what constitutes an agriPV project. India does not yet have formal standards, technical benchmarks or eligibility criteria.

"We should now scale it across all agro-climatic regions and generate reliable data on agricultural productivity, solar generation, and project economics," Pulipaka says. Krishi Vigyan Kendras and agricultural universities, he says, should lead these demonstrations by training farmers in identifying locally suitable cropping patterns and building confidence in the technology.

vanitabhatnagar@gmail.com

States

INBRIEF



DYFI Kerala elects its first woman president

Chintha Jerome, a Kollam native, has been elected the first woman president of the Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) in Kerala. A CPI(M) State committee member, Ms. Jerome was elected to the top post at the organisation's 16th State Conference in Thrissur on Saturday. She entered student politics through the Students' Federation of India (SFI) and rose through its ranks. Former SFI State secretary M. Vijin was elected for the same role in the DYFI.

Karnataka govt. bans sale of non-dairy paneer for one year

The Karnataka government has prohibited the manufacture, storage, distribution and sale of analogue or non-dairy paneer being sold as "paneer" across the State for one year, citing the need to protect public health and consumer interests. The order defines analogue or non-dairy paneer as a paneer-like product in which milk fat or milk solids have been wholly or partly replaced by vegetable oil, vegetable fat or other non-dairy ingredients.

Centre orders withdrawal of CISF from Vizag Steel Plant

In a major development concerning critical public sector infrastructure, the Union Ministry of Home Affairs is said to have approved the complete withdrawal of the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) from Rashtriya Ispat Nigam Limited, the corporate entity of Visakhapatnam Steel Plant by November 17. The pullback will affect 1,329 posts, comprising 1,033 personnel from the security wing and 298 from the fire wing, according to CISF Directorate General.

Karnataka SIR lists 16.38 lakh 'dead', 4 times State's average

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Of the over 1.08 crore voters identified till August 17, under the Absent, Shifted, Duplicate, Dead, and Other (ASDDO) categories in Karnataka, over 16.38 lakh have been marked as "dead".

What SRS indicates

Between 2002 and 2024, Karnataka's estimated total population deaths work out to around 98 lakh, or an average of about 4.45 lakh deaths a year, based on population estimates and the State's annual crude death rates reported through the Sample Registration System (SRS).

Governor summons PSC Secretary in Kerala

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar on Friday summoned Sajju George, Secretary of the Kerala Public Service Commission (KPSC), in connection with the alleged irregularities in the examinations.

The Governor sought general information on the present controversy and the progress of the investigation in the meeting held on Friday, sources said.

The PSC is battling a controversy over alleged anomalies in evaluation. A Special Investigation Team of the Crime Branch is probing the alleged malpractices.

Keralam to approach Centre against Railway bifurcation

Railways to detach Mangaluru region from Palakkad division and merge it with Mysuru division from Oct. 1: Satheshaan fears it will cause substantial losses to State; Karnataka rail patrons upbeat

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM/
MANGALURU

Keralam has lodged a strong protest against the Railway Board's decision to detach the Mangaluru region from the Palakkad division and merge it with the South Western Railway's Mysuru division.

The decision will take effect from October 1.

Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheshaan on Saturday called the Railway move unacceptable. "It will severely impact the revenue and development of the Southern Railway and Keralam. We will take up the



Mangaluru Junction is one of the three stations in Mangaluru region that will come under the South Western Railway. H.S. MANJUNATH

issue urgently with the Prime Minister and the Union Railway Minister," he said in a post on X. The merger of the Ullal-Mangaluru section, currently under the Southern Railway, with the South Western Railway would also cause substantial losses to the

Southern Railway and Keralam, the statement said. The decision was taken without any discussions with the State, it added.

Friends on Rail, a passenger association, said it could lead to the eventual elimination of several low-income stations, and ad-

versely affect Mangaluru-Keralam train services.

However, Pashchima Karavali Railway Yatri Abhivridhi Samithi and other rail patrons said Mr. Satheshaan's statement only corroborates the oft-repeated grievance of coastal Karnataka that rail revenues from Mangaluru were being used to develop rail infrastructure in Keralam. The samithi said more than half of the Palakkad division's revenue, about ₹800 crore a year, came from the Mangaluru region, particularly from New Mangalore Port.

Minister of State for Railways V. Somanna called the decision "historic".

Accused held a week after 3 deaths in A.P.

T. Appala Naidu
KAKINADA

Pro Rifle Shooting Academy founder, Sk. Sadhik Khan, 26, who allegedly drove an Andhra Pradesh Assistant Engineer and his family to end their lives, was arrested at Mosrut in Uttar Pradesh on Friday.

The bodies of Panchayat Raj Department Assistant Engineer K. Nooka Raju, his wife and their daughter were recovered from the Godavari in Rajamahendravaram city on August

16. Mr. Raju allegedly left behind a note accusing Mr. Khan of harassing his daughter and threatening his family. The next day, the police registered a case of abetment of suicide against Mr. Khan.

Eluru Range Inspector General of Police G.V.G. Ashok Kumar told The Hindu that seven teams had been deployed to nab Mr. Khan. He is likely to be produced before the media on Sunday. (Those in distress can seek help by calling Tele MANAS at 14416)

2 killed in Telangana pharma unit blast

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Two workers were killed and nine others suffered injuries after an alleged reactor blast triggered a massive fire at a pharmaceutical manufacturing unit at Douthigudem in Yadadri-Bhongir district of Telangana on Friday.

The deceased were identified as Chennu Nagi Reddy, 31, of Chinnagudem village in Nalgonda district, and Naganaboina Naresh Kumar, 29, of Choudaram

in Khammam district. The injured were rescued and shifted to two private hospitals.

The facility, Hazelo Lab, a one-storeyed building, is involved in the manufacture of Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients and bulk drug intermediates, according to a regulatory filing with the State Level Environmental Impact Assessment Authority.

Yadadri-Bhongir District Fire Officer Madhusudan said the cause of fire was under investigation.

Mann's wife sends notice to ex-judge over 'bribe' allegation

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI / CHANDIGARH

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's wife Gurpreet Kaur on Saturday sent a legal notice to a former Punjab and Haryana High Court judge in connection with the allegations that she sought ₹5 crore to suppress a rape case.

According to Aam Aadmi Party's Moga MLA Amandeep Kaur, Dr. Gurpreet has sent a legal notice seeking an apology within 24 hours, failing which legal proceedings would be initiated.

The matter came to light after the National Human Rights Commission issued a notice to the Punjab government and police chief over a complaint alleging that Mr. Mann's wife demanded ₹5 crore to suppress a rape case, officials said on Saturday.

'Give case to CBI'

State Congress president Amrinder Singh Raja Waring said serious allegations have been levelled and the CM should clarify on the issue.

The party's Jalandhar MP and former CM Charanjit Singh Channi said the matter should be inquired by CBI.

Shiromani Akali Dal leader and former Minister Bikram Singh Majithia also said that the CM should respond to the allegations and hand over the matter to CBI.

Ms. Amandeep launched a sharp attack on the Opposition, over what

she claimed were "baseless allegations".

Report in 2 weeks

Meanwhile, NHRC directed the authorities to probe the allegation and submit an action taken report within two weeks.

"The complainant alleged that a retired judge publicly stated that a demand of ₹5 crore was made in connection with a rape case, allegedly involving the wife of the CM of Punjab," the proceedings dated August 21 read.

An NHRC official said the Commission has taken cognisance of the allegation.

The complaint with NHRC, filed by Legal Rights Observatory, raised concerns that such "interference" could compromise the victim's right to dignity, safety, fair investigation and access to justice, they said. The complainant has requested independent verification of the allegation, preservation of evidence, and "impartial inquiry into any attempt to dilute or influence the investigation", and emphasised that a rape victim's right to justice must remain "above influence, status, or position".

The allegation prima facie seems to be a violation of the human rights of the victim, an NHRC Bench presided over by its member Priyank Kanoongo said after taking cognisance of the matter under Section 12 of the Protection of Human Rights Act, 1993, according to the proceedings.

Naidu defends data centre, rejects water shortage fears

Harish Gilai
ANAKAPALLI

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Saturday dismissed criticism surrounding Google's proposed data centre in Visakhapatnam, stating that those opposing the project fail to understand its potential benefits.

Refuting the claims that the Google data centre is contributing to water shortage in Visakhapatnam, he said construction of the project has not even gath-



N. Chandrababu Naidu

ered pace yet.

He was speaking at a public meeting after launching the "Swarna Andhra Swachh Andhra" programme at the Zilla

Parishad High School in A. Koduru village of K. Kotapadu mandal under the Madugula Assembly constituency.

Mr. Naidu said that rapid industrialisation and investments would help Anakapalli emerge as the number one district in the State over the next 25 years. Anakapalli, which is located about 34 km from Visakhapatnam, is now attracting investments across sectors, including steel, pharmaceuticals and data centres, he said.

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Classifieds

LIFE MADE SIMPLE

Marinomial

BRINGING PEOPLE TOGETHER

INDEX OF MATRIMONIAL

BRIDEGROOMS WANTED

BRIDES WANTED

BRIDES & GROOMS WANTED

Classification Common for Brides, Bridegrooms, Brides & Grooms

ASSAMESE

AWADHI

BENGALI

BHOJPURI

BIHARI

CHHATTISGARHI

ENGLISH

GUJARATI

HARYANI

HINDI

KANNADA

KASHMIRI

KONKANI

MALAYALAM

MANIPURI

MARATHI

MARWARI

NEPALI

ORIYA

PARSI

PUNJABI

SAURASHTRA

SINDHI

TAMIL

TELGU

TULU

URDU

ADVOCATE

BUSINESS

DEFENCE

DOCTOR

ENGINEER

FINANCE/BANKING

GOVERNMENT/QUASI-GOVERNMENT

(IAS) ALLIED SERVICES

INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

MBA/CA/ICWA

NRI

COSMOPOLITAN

DIVORCEE

PHYSICALLY CHALLENGED

MARRIAGE BUREAUS

WEDDING ARRANGEMENTS

BRIDEGROOMS WANTED

COSMOPOLITAN

BEAUTIFUL VEGETARIAN 32, 163cm, thoughtful, accomplished, UK-based (can relocate). Seeks compatible groom. Caste no bar. Call/WA 93456 34365

34YRS BTECH (NIT) MBA IIT working in MNC Chennai 24 LPA Fair looking for suitable match. Caste no bar. Call/WA 93456 34365

PROPOSALS invited from affluent families for Pillai / Nar girl, 25 years, related in UK & USA, very pretty and modern, law graduate, for intermarriage. Caste or language - No issues/contact: +1 602 491 5783

DIVORCEE

SAIVA MUDALIYAR, B.E., 160 Cms, 35 years, Working in MNC Company in Chennai, No issues. Seeks Tamil Vegetarian. Call: 8380723290

WARM, BEAUTIFUL, 49, sincere, responsible, progressive professional. Seeks kind, loyal, compatible groom. Caste no bar. Call/WA 93456 34365

DOCTOR

Affluent Hindu Nadar Family invites an Alliance for their daughter: 32 yrs, 5'4", Fair, Doctor, currently in USA (willing to relocate) Belongs to a prominent, wealthy background. Seeking a well educated groom, settled in USA or India. Ct: +91 9791994449 vsajsr@gmail.com

DOCTOR

HINDU, KERALA, Professional parents settled in USA seeking alliance for their daughter, 26 Years, MBBS presently doing MD in reputed college in India. Alliance invited from parents of doctors practicing/ studying in India or abroad. Caste no bar. Email: sreenivas@gmail.com

IAS / ALLIED SERVICES

WANTED GROOM

Hindu Reddy fair girl, 30 years, Height 5'2" B tech from IIT, Chennai, presently as IFS officer, preferred: IAS/IPS/IFS and other central govt Group A&B officers, preferably General & OBC category.

Contact what'sapp 9160666670 MailId y.aram.ssa@gmail.com

MALAYALAM

SC GIRL, 38, MBBS, Central government Group A officer. Caste no bar. 855881011.

HINDU YANNA, girl, Travancur, 28, 150 cm, M.Sc., Central Govt. job, JSE, DPS, Dept. of Atomic Energy Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu, 9446160288.

HINDU EZHAVA girl 31yrs, MA (IT), PhD (IT), 160cm, TVM, Asst Professor (English) at a reputed college seeks well educated working groom. Contact: +91960958011

DOCTOR

Alliance invited by parents for their 25-year-old, 164cm, fair and pleasant-looking Hindu Nair daughter from a well-educated, cultured family in Kerala. Currently pursuing MS in ENT at a reputed Government Medical college. Seeking a suitably qualified doctor with MD/MS from a respectable family background. 95676 21555 Email: mathiasvsn95@gmail.com

NRI

HINDU NADAR, 27 yrs, IAS. Wanted for Hindu Nadar 27 yrs USA. Contact: 98423-44133.

(IAS) ALLIED SERVICES

INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

MBA/CA/ICWA

NRI

COSMOPOLITAN

DIVORCEE

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TAMIL

VANNIYAKA SHATHIRYAR, B.O.S, 29 yrs, Poonam, Employed in Chennai looking for Groom Govt. Bank officer and Professional. CT: 984155051

GROOM WANTED Rich Mudaliyar 27yrs, MBA, Running own industries in Chennai. Ph:9952619776

HINDU SC/AD, Age:45, 153cm, Ashwin (Meha Raju) B.Sc., MBA Fair & Good Looking girl from Well to do Family. Seeking Engrs/Doctors/ Graduate - Officers. Ct: 9954219315 / 994329339

SC PR, Divorced no issue, 32yrs, B.E. CSC, fair, well settled in Madras, seeks suitable groom from reputed family. 97001 27258, 73388 28516

NADAR 35C 3" MBA working in Chennai. Elite Family Seeks qualified Groom working in Central, only Hindu. 992919179

BRIDEGROOM WANTED For a well-to-do Hindu family's bride age 43, Indian marriage, degree-MSW, want from FC, BC, MGR, working within India. Ph: 9841329471, 9380791999

GROOM WANTED Naidu 27yrs, Divorced, MBBS, Well Educated Family in Chennai. Ph:8382329227

GROOM WANTED Rich Mudaliyar 27yrs, MBBS, Well Educated Family in Chennai. Ph:8382329227

GROOM WANTED Hindu Nadar 28yrs, B.E., SWE, 1.5L pm, well educated and family Ph:9841329471, 9380791999

ALLIANCE INVITED for 26-year-old, Tamil, SC, well educated, postgraduate, working with a leading corporate law firm dealing in Capital Markets, advising on MNCs and banks on IPOs and major financial transactions. Intelligent, family-oriented with modern outlook and strong values. Seeking a well-educated, professionally accomplished groom, from a respectable family. Ph:944413558

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From Page One

Cong. alleges bulk voter purge bid in Uttarakhand

The Congress also offered the example of Kichha Assembly constituency in Udhampur Singh Nagar district, where one individual, Rajesh Tiwari, is stated to have submitted approximately 6,410 objections.

Congress MLA Qazi Muhammad Nizamuddin, who was part of the delegation that met with the EC, alleged that the manner in which the bulk forms were submitted online pointed to "institutional" access being granted to some organisation.

Mandatory review

However, EC sources said that, to prevent misuse of the process, if a person files more than five objections, it will trigger a mandatory review by the ERO to ensure the legitimacy of the claims.

The Congress memorandum claimed that several Form 7 objections in Uttarakhand have been filed by people who are not electors from, or in any other way connected with, the concerned Assembly Constituency.

It added that, according to the rules, the ERO has to conduct a summary inquiry and record a decision, with both the objector and the person objected to entitled to appear and be heard. However, in practice, this dual-notification requirement is not being observed, and in most cases, the objector is not present in the hearings, the memorandum said.

The Congress letter also said that unannounced exercises have restarted to identify demographically or photo-similar entries, proposing the deletion of 102,793 electors in Udhampur Singh Nagar district alone, without any proper written guidelines or due notice.

The draft electoral rolls of the State were published on July 14, with the final list to be released on September 15.

The claims and objections period was open till August 13, and the disposal of notices will take place till September 11.

Pressure mounts on BCI chief amid calls for exit

The controversy surrounding the BCI chairperson, who is also a Rajya Sabha MP from the Bharatiya Janata Party, intensified after the council issued a circular on August 13 directing State Bar Councils not to enrol graduates of NALSAR's 2026 batch, following objections by students to the participation of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant at their convocation. The directive was withdrawn within hours after an outcry from the legal fraternity. Mr. Mishra subsequently apologised to the students.

However, the apology did little to quell criticism. The Bombay Bar Association on August 18 criticised the handling of the episode and described the apology as "belated", while saying that Mr. Mishra ought to have already resigned.

In his letter on Saturday, Mr. Reddy called upon Mr. Mishra to resign and sought an independent examination of a range of issues relating to the functioning and financial administration of the council.

The letter raised questions over appointments within the BCI establishment, with Mr. Reddy alleging that a "striking proportion of the staff are persons connected to you (Mr. Mishra) personally, several of them being members of, or related to, your own family".

Mr. Reddy also questioned Mr. Mishra's prolonged occupancy of the chairmanship and argued for greater rotation and representation in the leadership of the apex regulatory body for the legal profession.

"You (Mr. Mishra) have held that office continuously since 2012, and were returned a further consecutive term in 2025. This is without precedent. When elections to the office fall due, the arrangements are so managed that the outcome is a foregone conclusion. An elected office that has one occupant for fourteen years has ceased, in any real sense, to be an elected office."

Curbs on cold medicine for children expanded

The Union government noted that the use of combinations containing chlorpheniramine maleate and phenylephrine hydrochloride may pose risks to children below four years of age and that safer alternatives are available.

At the same time, evidence that such combinations substantially improve uncomplicated colds in children is limited.

Manufacturers have been directed to prominently display the warning, "Fixed Dose Combination shall not be used in children below four years of age," on the label, package insert, and promotional literature associated with these formulations.

The notification has been issued under Section 26A of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940, in the interest of public health and is effective from the date of its publication in the Official Gazette.

India had already required warnings on certain formulations in 2023 and formally restricted the combination in 2025; the latest notification extends the restriction to all such FDC formulations for children below four.

Internationally, countries including the US and Australia, have also adopted age restrictions or other safeguards for paediatric cough-and-cold medicines.

Govt. promises permanent solution to Gorkha issue, sets up committee

Gorkhas have been seeking a separate State of Gorkhaland comprising parts of Darjeeling hills and adjoining areas; Shah assures the community of a political solution under the ambit of Constitution; he also promises adequate Central funding

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The Union government on Saturday decided to set up a committee to draft an agreement and finalise modalities for a "permanent political solution" to the demands of the Gorkha community in the Darjeeling hills and adjoining areas of north Bengal.

The committee has been demanding the creation of a separate State of Gorkhaland, to be carved out of territories in the Darjeeling hills and adjoining areas.

Saturday's announcement came at a meeting in Siliguri chaired by Union Home Minister Amit Shah and attended by West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, Darjeeling BJP MP Raju Bista, and other leaders from different political parties of the region.

"It was decided to constitute a committee, chaired by the former deputy National Security Adviser and current interlocutor Shri Pankaj Kumar Singh, to finalise the modalities," a statement from the Union Home Ministry said.



Home Minister Amit Shah, West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari and other dignitaries at a meeting in Siliguri on Saturday. PTI

autonomous bodies such as the Darjeeling Gorkha Hill Council in 1988 and the Gorkhaland Territorial Administration (GTA) in 2011 had failed to live up to the aspirations and expectations of the people.

According to the Home Ministry, during the meeting on Saturday, all issues concerning the hill population of West Bengal were discussed in detail, and

Statehood demand
The demand for a Gorkhaland State has been alive since the 1980s. The earlier arrangements of regional

"demands regarding their identity, a permanent political solution, and recognition under the Constitution were taken up".

The statement added that Mr. Shah promised a permanent political solution soon under the umbrella of the Constitution and promised to sympathetically look into all other demands of the Gorkha community. He also said that adequate funding from the Centre will take care of all pending issues.

In October 2025, the Centre appointed former Deputy National Security Adviser Pankaj Kumar Singh as the interlocutor to hold talks with Gorkha representatives to address their political demands.

The issue has dominated the politics of Darjeeling hills over the past several decades. The region has been voting for the BJP over the past two decades, and the party has been

promising a permanent political solution.

Speaking to presspersons after the meeting, Mr. Bista said representatives of all political parties were present at the meeting. Harshvardhan Sringhla, former IFS officer and Rajya Sabha MP, said the meeting had set the ball rolling for a solution to the Gorkhaland issue.

Gorkha Janmukti Morcha leader Roshan Giri said the meeting aimed at resolving the Gorkhaland issue under the ambit of the Constitution. Among those present at the meeting were GJM chief Bimal Gurung and Gorkha National Liberation Front chief Mann Ghisingh.

While the parties in the Darjeeling hills are in support of statehood for Gorkhaland, the development will have repercussions in south Bengal as the people there do not want any division of the State.

Rescue efforts on after cargo ship sinks in Bay of Bengal

Press Trust of India
PARADIP

A Panama-flagged cargo ship with 24 crew members, mostly Chinese, sank in the Bay of Bengal on Saturday, about 240 nautical miles off the Odisha coast, officials said.

Twenty of the crew members on the ship, *MV Ocean Winner*, were Chinese, three Myanmar and one Bangladeshi, they said.

The ship was heading to Singapore carrying 72,100 mt of iron ore fines from Odisha. It had left the Paradip coast at 10.42 p.m. on August 20, they added.

"The Indian Coast Guard and Indian Navy have launched a rescue operation. So far, two persons have been rescued from the waters," a senior IPS officer said.

Another nearby ship has also come to the rescue of *MV Ocean Winner*, he said. Efforts are being made to establish contact with the crew members.

Courts must speak language of rule of law, economics: CJI

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Saturday highlighted that courts must speak the language of both the rule of law and economics, coining the combination as "Nyaya-nomics".

He said courts must ensure trust, predictability and stability in the justice delivery system in order to spur economic growth. He was speaking at the 11th BRICS Legal Forum organised by the Bar Association of India.

"Institutions are not the scaffolding that we erect around growth once it has already begun. They are its architecture. Take the architecture away, and in truth, what looks like a rising economy is a stack of good fortune waiting for its first storm. This architecture, upheld primarily by institutions such as the justice delivery system, offers three things: trust, predictability, and stability, each a direct byproduct of a studied allegiance to the Rule of Law," the Chief Justice said. He said consistency in jurisprudence allows an economy, including India's own, to flourish at a growing pace. "The term that would perfectly describe the marriage between the Rule of Law and how it permeates favourable economic conditions: 'Nyaya-nomics', or more simply, the economics of justice," the CJI said.

"To my mind, a courtroom that keeps its word quickly becomes a country the world is willing to trust with its capital," he said.



Chief Justice Surya Kant

Press clubs must take proactive role in restoring media credibility: N. Ram

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

Veteran journalist and Director of The Hindu Group N. Ram identified two interconnected challenges confronting journalism — an erosion of public trust in the media and growing threats to its freedom and independence — and called for press clubs across the country to play a proactive role in restoring credibility.

Speaking at the National Convolve of the Federation of Press Clubs in Hyderabad on Saturday, he said the credibility crisis could not be attributed entirely to forces outside journalism. Political propaganda, misinformation and disinformation on social media had contributed to the trust deficit, but sections of the media had also contributed to the problem through sensationalism, inadequate verification, communal rhetoric and excessive proximity to political and corporate interests.



Telangana Deputy CM Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka with The Hindu Group Director N. Ram at a photo exhibition during the Federation of Press Clubs' first national conference on Saturday. NAGARA GOPAL

"When journalism becomes indistinguishable from political propaganda" and when television debates substitute "noise for information", public trust inevitably suffers, he said, stressing that credibility could neither be taken for granted nor demanded from the public.

Mr. Ram argued that a free press could not survive on constitutional and legal safeguards alone, and that public trust was equally crucial to its remaining

an effective democratic institution.

Against the backdrop of the media's dwindling credibility, he said press clubs had an important role in rebuilding that trust by promoting professional ethics and independence.

1988 protest

On threats to media freedom, he said coercive tactics against journalists were not confined to any one political party or government. State govern-

ments of different political affiliations had also resorted to measures such as filing criminal cases, police action and attempts to arrest journalists.

He recalled how a collective effort could force a government to take corrective measures, citing the Rajiv Gandhi government's unconditional withdrawal of the Defamation Bill in 1988 after protests by journalists.

The modern state had formidable instruments at its disposal, including criminal prosecution, police investigations, raids, seizure of electronic devices and surveillance. However, a pluralistic media environment made it difficult for any government to completely control the press, he felt.

The Federation of Press Clubs in India, Mr. Ram said, could establish a national network capable of responding quickly whenever journalists faced threats anywhere in the country.

BCI trust controversy deepens over ₹150-crore fund transfer; Chair turns down allegations

Soibam Rocky Singh
NEW DELHI

The demand for the resignation of Bar Council of India (BCI) chairman Manan Kumar Mishra has brought into focus a wider institutional controversy surrounding the creation of BCI Trust PEARL-FIRST and allegations that the original BCI Trust was rendered defunct.

In a six-page letter dated August 22, BCI co-chairman and senior advocate Y.R. Sadasisa Reddy levelled several allegations concerning the creation of BCI Trust PEARL-FIRST, the transfer of around ₹150 crore from BCI funds to the trust, alleged demands for contributions from law colleges, and the handling of funds generated through the All-India Bar Examination (AIBE).

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Mr. Reddy said he had "strongly opposed" the

Reddy alleges that PEARL-FIRST audit reports were never placed before the BCI by Mishra

proposal to transfer ₹150 crore to the trust and that other members had also recorded their objections, but the transfer ultimately went through. He further alleged that Mr. Mishra had never placed the audit reports of the PEARL-FIRST trust before a meeting of the BCI since the trust's inception in 2020. "I have never seen these audit reports," Mr. Reddy said.

'Baseless allegations'
Responding to queries sent by *The Hindu*, Mr. Mishra said, "Mr. Sadasisa Reddy is not the co-chairman of the Bar Council of India. Presently, he is not even a member of a State Bar Council. He is politically

opposed to me and in the Bar Council, [while he was a member], he had made all efforts to oppose me in elections, but he couldn't get a proposer even to contest."

"Those are the reasons for making all sorts of frivolous and baseless allegations. Everything is audited by a certified C.A. every year," Mr. Mishra said.

Mr. Reddy said the original BCI Trust, an institution created in 1974, was allowed to fall into disuse during Mr. Mishra's tenure and was replaced by BCI Trust PEARL-FIRST, whose trustees, he alleged, were chosen by Mr. Mishra.

He also alleged that the managements of new law colleges approaching the BCI for approval, as well as those of existing colleges seeking renewal, were required to make "contributions" to the PEARL-FIRST trust, ranging from ₹25 lakh to ₹1 crore.

Assam and Meghalaya step up efforts to end standoff, agree on measures to ensure safety

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Assam and Meghalaya on Saturday sought an end to the standoff between people of the two States following the violence during a "black flag bike rally" organised by the Khasi Students' Union in Shillong on August 19.

Transporters and members of various organisations in Assam blocked the Guwahati-Shillong highway for the third consecutive day on Saturday, demanding an end to recurring attacks on Assam-registered vehicles and tourists.

In a bid to end the conflict, Meghalaya Deputy Chief Minister Sniawbhang Dhar met Assam Border Protection and Development Minister Atul Bora in Guwahati on Saturday.

The two governments agreed to establish a dedicated coordination me-



Transporters block the Assam-Meghalaya border at Jorabat amid tensions following violence during a KSU rally in Shillong. PTI

chanism between the Inspector General (IG) of Assam Police's Special Branch and the IG (Law & Order), Meghalaya, along with dedicated helplines.

An online support forum will also be activated to help locate and facilitate stranded individuals.

A joint committee comprising the Commissioner/Secretary-level transport authorities of both States, along with representatives of the tourist vehicle associations, would be consti-

tuted to regulate tourist transport movement and safeguard the shared tourism interests of Assam and Meghalaya.

The Meghalaya government reiterated that it would take responsibility for the safety of all tourists and vehicles travelling from Assam and other parts of the country into Meghalaya, during their stay within the State. Mr. Bora said both States would take necessary steps for the safety of vehicles.

Assam floods: MLA blames BJP legislators for deaths

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Rights activist-turned-Sivasagar MLA Akhil Gogoi on Saturday held three Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) legislators, including a Minister, responsible for the deaths and devastation caused by floods in parts of eastern Assam.

At least 105 people were killed and more than 7.5 lakh affected between April and mid-August. Flash floods triggered by heavy rain in Nagaland caused much of the damage in Sivasagar, Charaideo and Jorhat districts.

Mr. Gogoi rejected Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's claim that a cloudburst caused the floods, citing coal mining along the Assam-Nagaland border and damage to natural river protection structures along the Dikhow. "I had sent a special team with drones. It found five cofferdams across the Dikhow River, creating a 350-km-long reservoir upstream. Protective stone embankments had also been excavated along a 25-km stretch," he said.

He accused Water Resources Minister Sushanta Borgohain and MLAs Dhamenwar Konwar and Mayur Borgohain of controlling a mining syndicate.

BJP passes resolution against Cong. decision on Vande Mataram stanzas

The party steps up preparations for a nationwide Gen-Z outreach programme; another meeting focused on a programme from Sept. 17 to Oct. 17, marking PM Modi's birthday; Nitin Nabin holds first meeting with new national office-bearers

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Saturday passed a resolution criticising the Congress Working Committee's decision to reaffirm its 1937 resolution and restrict the singing of *Vande Mataram* to its first two stanzas at Congress events. The party also stepped up preparations for a nationwide Gen-Z outreach programme.

BJP president Nitin Nabin held his first meeting with the newly-appointed national office-bearers, which was also attended by their predecessors. In the evening, Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressed the new team.

Connect with youth: PM "Organisational meetings are all about new ideas and perspectives aimed at strengthening the Party and deepening connect with the people. Great interaction with fellow Party colleagues and the new organisational team!" said Mr. Modi on X.

During the meeting, the Prime Minister exhorted the new office-bearers to



Putting pressure: BJP national president Nitin Nabin, second left, with party leaders during Nabin's first meeting with the party's newly appointed national office-bearers in New Delhi on Saturday. PTI

intensify the outreach with the young generation.

The day's meetings focused on strengthening the BJP's connect with the people, particularly the young generation. The party decided to constitute a team for its upcoming Gen-Z outreach programme, to understand the aspirations and concerns of the younger generation. The team is likely to include Mr. Nabin, national general secretaries Smriti Irani and Vinod Tawde, Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi, and

Chhattisgarh Minister O.P. Choudhary.

Another meeting focused on the decision to run a month-long programme across the country from September 17 to October 17, marking Mr. Modi's birthday and 25 years since he became Gujarat Chief Minister.

Constitutional status

In its 10-point resolution on *Vande Mataram*, the BJP rejected what it described as attempts to subordinate the song to communal pressure, political ap-

peasement or vote-bank politics. The party said the Congress Working Committee's 1937 decision could not override constitutional institutions or laws.

It resolved to "affirm the constitutional and statutory status of *Vande Mataram* as established by the Constituent Assembly's 1950 pronouncement and reinforced by Parliament's 2026 amendment [the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act] extending statutory protection to the

National Song equivalent to that accorded to the National Anthem".

The BJP announced a nationwide campaign through its workers to educate people, particularly the youth, about the National Song's history, six-stanza composition and national significance.

"That legacy cannot be reduced to the calculations of contemporary vote-bank politics. The same *Vande Mataram* that echoed as the call for freedom in 1947 will resound as the supreme chant for a 'Developed India @ 2047' under the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi," it said.

At a press conference, BJP MP Sambit Patra referred to a complaint filed with the police seeking registration of a case to probe alleged "intentional obstruction/disturbance" during the rendition of the National Song at the All India Congress Committee headquarters on August 15.

Mr. Patra said the recently enacted Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act prescribed imprisonment and a fine, and that the law would take its course.

Cong. flags concerns over SC's ruling on 'industry' definition

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Saturday expressed concern over the Supreme Court's recent ruling on the definition of "industry", saying any move to narrow the scope of the law could weaken safeguards available to workers.

The judgment in *State of Uttar Pradesh vs Jai Bir Singh*, delivered on August 20, 2026, had raised important questions about the future interpretation of labour law, Congress general secretary in-charge of communications Jairam Ramesh said.

The Modi government's Industrial Relations Code, 2020, had already "significantly weakened essential safeguards for our workers," he said.

The Supreme Court's majority judgment revisited the interpretation of "industry" laid down in its landmark 1978 judgment in the *Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board vs A. Rajappa* case, in which the court had evolved the "Triple Test" — systematic activity, cooperation between employer and employee and production or distribution of goods or services to satisfy human wants and wishes.

The judgment had also held that the absence of a profit motive did not by itself take an activity outside the definition of an industry. The main exception was core sovereign functions, including the judiciary, law and order and defence.

This broad interpretation had, for nearly five decades, brought a wide range of workers within the protection of labour laws, Mr. Ramesh said. The recent majority judgment, he claimed, sought to narrow the approach by requiring an activity to have a "discernible commercial character" resembling trade or business. It also widened the scope of the sovereign-function exemption, potentially excluding more government activities from the definition of



The August 20 judgment is concerning because it injects uncertainty into labour relations at a time when clarity is essential for industrial peace
JAIRAM RAMESH
Congress general secretary

"industry", he added.

"The Supreme Court has clarified that this reformulation will not disturb concluded or pending proceedings under the erstwhile Industrial Disputes Act as amended from time to time, and will not govern the interpretation of the new Industrial Relations Code. But leaving this 'hypothesis' on the record creates an interpretive vacuum that could open a Pandora's box of litigation and uncertainty, particularly before Labour Courts and Industrial Tribunals," Mr. Ramesh said.

He praised Justice B.V. Nagarathna's dissent, saying she had rightly held that the 1978 judgment did not require reconsideration and had cautioned against disturbing settled law.

"The August 2026 majority judgment is concerning because it injects uncertainty into labour relations at a time when clarity is essential for industrial peace," Mr. Ramesh said.

Be loud, proud and fight for your space: Rahul to Gen Z girls



Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi during an interaction at 'Chhatron ki Goonj' on Saturday. EMANUAL YOGINI

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
PUNE

In his fourth 'Chhatron ki Goonj' address, held in Pune on Saturday, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi urged Gen Z women to "smash" the patriarchy.

"Be loud, be proud and fight for your space in society," he told the girl students at the AISSMS ground on Saturday evening amid a rousing welcome. Speaking in Marathi, he said, "*Pune mhanje prem* (Pune means love)".

His address, which last-

ed well over an hour, was interspersed with interactions with young women from different backgrounds who spoke of their concerns.

Mr. Gandhi said the 70 crore women of India are more important than the 70 crore men of the country.

Calling the BJP leadership responsible for the "return of the Manusmriti", he played a clip of Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressing shock at the foul language used by young girls during the Jantar Mantar protest, term-

ing it a "cultural shock."

"At Jantar Mantar, bad words were used by both boys and girls. And yet, the PM expressed cultural shock only about the girls. The message was that it is okay for the boys to use bad words, not the girls," he said.

"We don't want an India where it is believed that boys should get full freedom, but that girls should be kept in a cage at home. We want justice. We want everyone to be respected. The fear from your hearts should be erased at the earliest. You are the founda-

tion, the future of this country," Mr. Gandhi said.

Ways of control

"Women are controlled through violence. Every six out of 100 women are raped in India. That is direct physical violence. There is violence of opportunity, whereby 50% of women reject jobs due to safety concerns. There is financial violence, where ₹1,500 are spent annually for the safety of a woman. So there is direct, financial and opportunity violence for the women in our country," he said.

Congress slams Centre for failing to contain increase in prices of essential commodities

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Saturday accused the Narendra Modi government of failing to contain the rise in prices of essential commodities, with party president Mallikarjun Kharge questioning whether the diversion of sugarcane and grain for ethanol production under the E20 policy was contributing to rising sugar prices.

In a post on X, Mr. Kharge said sugar stocks

were at a nine-year low even as prices had risen sharply ahead of the festival season. He asked why India, the world's largest sugar producer and exporter, had reached a situation where exports had to be halted and one million tonnes of sugar imported duty-free.

Mr. Kharge said sugar had become nearly 40% more expensive in recent months and questioned the rationale for diverting sugarcane and grain towards ethanol when the

Kharge asks if diverting sugarcane for ethanol was leading to rise in sugar prices

country was importing sugar. "What kind of 'self-reliant India' is this?" he asked, arguing that the policy had resulted in declining sugar production and stocks while sugar was being imported.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh also at-

tacked the government over inflation, saying the rise in prices was affecting household budgets and not just kitchen essentials.

"From soap to cars, from spices to flour, rice, sugar and oil, inflation has broken the back of the common man," Mr. Ramesh said in a social media post.

Citing price increases over the past month, he said flour had risen from ₹32 to ₹40 a kg, rice from ₹42 to ₹54, cumin from ₹180 to ₹380 and turmeric from ₹130 to ₹260. Mustard

oil, peanut oil and refined oil had also registered sharp increases, he said.

'Public won't forget'

Mr. Ramesh said the rising cost of everyday goods, including soap, detergent, toothpaste, biscuits, tyres and cars, had made life difficult for ordinary people. "There is no effort to control inflation," he said, warning that the public would remember the government's handling of prices and "will not forgive".

Manipur CM lauds transport resumption

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Manipur Chief Minister Nymman Khemchand Singh on Saturday said the resumption of bus and commercial vehicle services between Imphal and Guwahati would go a long way in providing relief to people in the State.

People in Manipur, particularly those living in the

Imphal Valley, have had to depend on air travel since May 3, 2023, when the ethnic conflict erupted.

"The resumption of public road transport services (between Imphal and Guwahati) will provide much-needed relief to our people, particularly students studying outside the State and those travelling for medical treatment," the Chief Minister said.

डॉ. हरिसिंह गौर विश्वविद्यालय, सागर (म.प्र.)
Dr. Harisingh Gour Vishwavidyalaya, Sagor (M.P.)
"A Central University" | A+ Grade by NAAC (Fourth Cycle)
Ref. No. /DoFA/BM/GF/2026/310 Date: 21-08-2026

WALK-IN INTERVIEW
DEPARTMENT OF BUSINESS MANAGEMENT

Applications are invited for the engagement of Guest Faculty (per lecture basis) under the Self Financing Scheme in the Department of Business Management of the university. Applicants are advised to visit Website Link: <https://dhsgsu.edu.in/recruitment> for detailed advertisement and application form.

Date of interview : 31.08.2026
Time of interview : 10.30 AM
Venue of interview : Gour Samiti Kaksha, Main Administrative Building
Dr. Harisingh Gour Vishwavidyalaya
Website link : <https://dhsgsu.edu.in/recruitment> Registrar

PURABI DAIRY
West Assam Milk Producers' Co-operative Union Ltd. (WAMUL)
Under National Programme for Dairy Development-Govt. of India
R.K. Jyoti Prasad Agarwala Road, Panjabari, Guwahati-781037, Assam
Website: www.purabi.coop

WAMUL/NPDD/26-27/01 Date: 23.08.2026

Tender Notice

National Programme for Dairy Development (NPDD), a Government of India Scheme, has been restructured with the aim of enhancing quality of milk and milk products and West Assam Milk Producers' Cooperative Union Limited (WAMUL), is the implementing agency for Assam. WAMUL now invites eligible bidders for participating in the tender as described below:

No.	Description	Date of publishing Tender	Last date of submission	Platform of tender publication
1.	Automatic Milk Collection System (AMCS)	25-08-2026	15-09-2026	www.assamtenders.gov.in

If any corrigendum is issued, it will be published in www.assamtenders.gov.in on or before last date and time for submission of bid. No separate notification for publication of corrigendum or extension of last date of submission of bid will be made through Newspaper advertisement.

For any details please contact
Smt. Sandhya Kalita, Group Head- Purchase & Stores
Phone: +91 977013600
E-mail: sandhya@purabi.coop
Sd/- Group Head-Purchase & Stores
WAMUL (Purabi Dairy)

अखिल भारतीय आयुर्विज्ञान संस्थान, गोरखपुर
All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Gorakhpur
(एनएमएस) (एनएमएस) (एनएमएस) (एनएमएस) (एनएमएस)
(An autonomous organization under the Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Govt. of India)
Website: www.aiimsgorakhpur.edu.in

NON-FACULTY APPOINTMENTS

Offline applications from eligible Indian citizens/other citizens as permissible under the applicable Act/ Rules are invited to fill up following Non-Faculty (Group A, B & C) various posts on DEPUTATION BASIS at All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Gorakhpur (Uttar Pradesh):

Sl. No.	Name of Post	Group	Level as per 7 th CPC	No. of Posts
1.	Medical Superintendent	A	Level-14 (Rs. 144200-218200) + NPA	01
2.	Registrar	A	Level-12 (Rs. 78800-209200)	01
3.	Executive Engineer (Civil)	A	Level-11 (Rs. 67700-208700)	01
4.	Executive Engineer (Electrical)	A	Level-11 (Rs. 67700-208700)	01
5.	Senior Accounts Officer	A	Level-11 (Rs. 67700-208700)	01
6.	Assistant Administrative Officer	B	Level-07 (Rs. 44900-142400)	01
7.	Assistant Account Officer	B	Level-07 (Rs. 44900-142400)	02
8.	Office Superintendent	B	Level-06 (Rs. 35400-112400)	01
9.	Upper Division Clerk	C	Level-04 (Rs. 25500-81100)	01
	Total Posts			10

The above vacancies are provisional and subject to variation. The Executive Director, AIIMS, Gorakhpur reserves the right to change the number of the vacancies including reserved vacancies as per the Govt. of India rules/circulars. Application form, eligibility criteria, desirable qualifications/experience, and related details, please visit www.aiimsgorakhpur.edu.in
All the applicants are advised to check AIIMS, Gorakhpur website www.aiimsgorakhpur.edu.in on Deputation basis for any further updates.

Sd/-
Executive Director
AIIMS Gorakhpur
Kunraghat, Gorakhpur, Uttar Pradesh 273008

IN BRIEF



Court denies bail to accused in Pulwama terror attack

A special NIA court has rejected the bail plea of Insha Jan alias Insha Tariq, an accused in the 2019 Pulwama suicide attack that killed 40 CRPF personnel, observing that sufficient material existed on record to presume that the accusations against her were prima facie true. In his 15-page order delivered on August 20, Special Judge Prem Sagar held that the statutory bar under Section 43(D)(5) of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) also operated against the accused and prevented her release on bail at this stage. Jan, a resident of Harkipora village in south Kashmir's Pulwama district, was arrested on March 3, 2020. **PH**

At least three workers die in steel factory fire in Jharkhand

At least three employees of a steel factory in Jharkhand's Ramgarh district died, and one was injured after a fire broke out in the unit, police said on Saturday. The blaze spread from a captive power plant in the steel factory in Helal at midnight on Friday. "At least four employees received severe burn injuries. Three of them died during treatment in a hospital," said Ramgarh Superintendent of Police (SP) Mukesh Kumar Lunayat. He said the exact cause of the fire is being investigated. Barkakana Police Station in-charge Uma Shankar Verma said the deceased have been identified as Sanjeev, Vinit and Abhishek. **PH**

Five killed as bus ploughs into crowd in Bihar's Champaran

At least five people were killed, and several others were injured when a bus ploughed into a crowd attending a cultural programme in Bihar's West Champaran district, police said on Saturday. The incident took place around 10:45 p.m. on Friday along the Lauriya Marg in Parau Tola under the jurisdiction of Lauriya police station. "While trying to avert a head-on collision with a truck, the bus ploughed into a crowd attending a cultural event on the roadside, killing five men and injuring several others," said Narkatiyaganj Sub-divisional Police Officer (SDPO) Ajay Prakash Singh. The incident led to a stampede-like situation, he added. **PH**

21-year-old Indian held in U.S. over fraud targeting elderly

An Indian national has been arrested and charged in the U.S. for his alleged role as a "money mule" in a multi-million-dollar scheme targeting elderly victims. Jay Sunilbharthi Goswami, 21, a Gujarat native who lived in New Jersey, was detained in Canada while attempting to flee to Qatar. He was charged by criminal complaint with wire fraud, conspiracy to commit wire fraud, money laundering and conspiracy to commit money laundering. The charges carry a maximum penalty of 20 years in prison, U.S. Attorney Michael DiGiacomo said Friday. Canadian authorities detained Goswami at Toronto Pearson International Airport. **PH**

SUDOKU

5			9			8		
9		8			2		7	
3		7	5			9		4
		3	6		7			
8								7
				9		6	3	
2		5			6	7		1
	7		4			2		9
		1		9				3

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

2	4	3	6	1	7	9	8	5
7	1	6	5	8	9	4	2	3
5	9	8	3	4	2	6	7	1
4	2	5	1	3	6	8	9	7
3	8	7	9	2	5	1	4	6
9	6	1	8	7	4	5	3	2
6	5	2	4	9	3	7	1	8
1	3	9	7	5	8	2	6	4
8	7	4	2	6	1	3	5	9

Reclaiming Assam's elephant habitat, one weed at a time

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

A project in Assam to improve the quality of an elephant habitat could turn a botanical liability into a carbon-rich asset.

For decades, Assam Forest Department officials have struggled to deal with at least half a dozen invasive alien plants (IAPs) that have been constricting local vegetation and reducing the food options for herbivores.

The forest officials are upbeat about the targeted IAP management in Khalingduar Reserve Forest under the Dhanisiri Forest Division of Udalguri district, bordering Bhutan.

A two-hectare area has been selected in this reserve forest in the Bodo-land Territorial Region

(BTR) for the project focused on managing three IAP species.

Species in question

The species concerned are *Lantana camara*, *Chromolaena odorata*, and *Mikania micrantha*. Although these species have been known to contribute as nectar resources or structural cover, their proliferation is altering native plant communities and constraining regeneration.

Aaranyak, a Guwahati-based biodiversity conservation organisation, is undertaking the International Elephant Foundation-supported project.

The programme targets native vegetation recovery through targeted IAP management, seed-bank-assisted regeneration, and conversion of cleared biomass



Invasive alien plant species converted into biochar to improve forest health in Assam's Udalguri district. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

into biochar.

Biochar is a fine-grained, porous, charcoal-like substance made by heating organic waste in a controlled environment with little to no oxygen. Instead of burning to ash, this thermal process transforms the biomass into a

stable, solid form of carbon that resists decay and can remain in the ground for thousands of years.

Biochar properties vary considerably with feedstock and production conditions. Its porous structure can influence soil water retention, nutrient

retention, aggregation, and microbial habitat.

Hope for herbivores

According to Aaranyak's Rabiya Daimari, Bistina Burhagohain, Bikash Tossa, Manav Nayak, and Pradip Barman, a quintet conducting the field operations for the project, the three invasive species compete with native vegetation for light, space, moisture, and nutrients.

These IAPs gradually stifle the growth and recovery of native grasses, herbs, shrubs, and naturally regenerating trees. "Elephants and other herbivores need a varied forage base comprising local grasses and plants," a team member said.

The quintet said the existing vegetation in the project area was catalogued to

identify patches with substantial IAP dominance. Based on the survey findings, the IAPs were manually uprooted in the target area to minimise regrowth and reduce competitive pressure on regenerating vegetation.

"The Khalingduar project can be a game-changer for the management of IAPs," Sonali Ghosh, the Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forests and BTR's Council Head of Department, told *The Hindu* on Saturday.

The Aaranyak team said the project area would be monitored periodically for IAP re-emergence and regeneration, with subsequent removal undertaken to prevent renewed dominance and sustain the space created for native vegetation recovery.

Infant dead, 2 injured in fire at NICU in M.P. govt. hospital

Chhindwara district hospital in-charge denies negligence after radiant warmer machine at facility caught fire due to sparks in its filament coil, causing injuries to three children; probe under way

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

An infant was killed and two other newborns suffered burn injuries after a fire broke out in the neonatal ICU (NICU) at the government district hospital in Madhya Pradesh's Chhindwara, officials said on Saturday.

According to officials, the incident took place around 1.50 a.m. after a radiant warmer machine in the NICU caught fire due to sparks in its filament coil, causing injuries to three children.

Hospital in-charge and civil surgeon Kanchan Dubey said that after an initial examination, the three infants were referred to the government medical college in Jabalpur.

"There were a total of 33 children there [in the NICU] and three [infants] were placed on the same warmer. Our staff, including nurses, acted with promptness and saved the other 30 children. They were initially moved to another unit and after

An infant being carried away after a fire broke out in the neonatal ICU of the government hospital in Chhindwara, Madhya Pradesh. **PH**

technicians and electricians inspected all other machines, the children were shifted back to the NICU," she said, terming the tragedy an accident.

"The administrative officials will come and conduct an investigation but I don't see any negligence in this. It is an accident," she said, adding that the fire was quickly doused.

Dr. Dubey also denied any technical fault in the machine.

Roopmal Parna, a relative of the deceased girl child, said the families had initially been told that all children were safe.

"I was among the first to

reach the spot and the room was filled with smoke. There is so much negligence here. The nursing staff even asks for money [from families] saying that they will do the delivery properly," he said.

they were sent to Jabalpur for better treatment," Dr. Lamba said. "There was a short circuit in the coil. It did not happen anywhere in the electrical line, the short circuit occurred only in the coil. The problem is that the oxygen tubing also runs from that very area. The short circuit produced sparks, which fell on the oxygen tubing, and caused fire in the cradle. The staff managed to bring out the three children from the cradle within 15 seconds but due to the foam mattress, they suffered burn injuries," he said.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Chhindwara Collector Harendra Narayan Mishra said an investigation has been ordered.

"I have been told by the hospital that the machine had undergone its annual maintenance on August 10 and no fault had been detected. But since a tragedy has happened, we have informed the maintenance agency in Bhopal. Their engineers will visit the hospital soon for an inspection," he said.

No paediatric surgeon

District hospital paediatrician Anshul Lamba said the children were referred to the facility in Jabalpur as there was no paediatric surgeon at the hospital.

"After the primary treatment, surgical inspection was conducted by specialists and opinion was taken. Since, we do not have a paediatric surgeon here,

Amid controversy, NCERT team head promises to bring out factual, unbiased books

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

Following a political controversy over the reconstitution of the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) committee that brings out political science textbooks for Classes 11 and 12, members of the newly formed panel have said "personal political affiliations will be set aside" while working on the textbooks.

The reconstituted 20-member committee faced criticism from Opposition parties and student bodies over reported links to RSS-affiliated organisations.

In an interview with *The Hindu*, Sandeep Shastri, Textbook Development Team (TDT) head and Vice President (Bengaluru campus) of Nitte University, said he would endeavour to bring out factual and unbiased textbooks.

"We have been assigned to work on Class 11 and 12



Sandeep Shastri

political science textbooks. Fellow members of my team are essentially subject experts, and that is important to me. I want to work on a book that is factual and unbiased. That is the mandate that I have given to myself," said Mr. Shastri.

"Over the last decade, I have worked with a wide range of people. We may choose to agree or not agree on certain topics. In case we do not agree, we work to arrive at an agreement," he added.

Before joining the Karnataka-based Nitte Education Trust, Mr. Shastri

served as the Vice Chancellor of IIT-based Jagran Lake University.

Of the 20 members in the TDT, at least four members – Yadunath Deshpande, Prashant Divekar, Vandana Mishra and Ravi Rameshchandra – have links with the BJP, the RSS or the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP).

On political affiliations

A TDT member, who spoke on the condition of anonymity, said, "Our political lineage, Left or Right, is immaterial when we meet as a group. We should not bring the ideology of any political party to the table. Everybody has their own life post academics, but when we meet for a particular purpose, we put those hats aside."

"We should have a healthy debate. It is not that everything old will be erased, but a sense of contemporaneity will be brought into the textbooks," the member added.

Shubhomov Sikdar
RAIPUR

A professor at a private college in Chhattisgarh's Durg district and five students from the same institution were arrested for their alleged roles in the leak of an Indira Gandhi Krishi Vishwavidyalaya (IGKV) entomology question paper, police said on Saturday.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Crime and Cyber) Smruthik Rajanala told *The Hindu* that 38-year-old Yogesh Sonkesariya, a professor at Bharti Agriculture College in Durg, had allegedly used an endoscopic camera to capture images of the question papers that he received in a sealed envelope and then shared them with his fellow accused before the exam, which was scheduled to be held on August 20.

The officer alleged that the accused were also involved in leaking the question paper of another examination that was scheduled for August 7.

SC sets aside order against Art of Living for Yamuna event

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Saturday set aside a December 2017 decision of the National Green Tribunal (NGT) holding Sri Sri Ravi Shankar's Art of Living Foundation responsible for the damage caused to the Yamuna floodplains during its World Culture Festival held in 2016.

A Bench of Justices Satish Chandra Sharma and N.K. Singh directed the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to refund ₹5 crore deposited by the foundation with it in four weeks.

The top court's order came on an appeal filed by Vyakti Vikas Kendra India, associated with the Art of Living Foundation.

Criticises nod for event

The court disapproved of the manner in which the DDA granted permission to hold the event on an active floodplain. "It was not only avoidable, but was also not consistent with the precautionary principle and doctrine of public trust," Justice Sharma, who authored the judgment, observed.

The Bench said the DDA should continue to carry

out the rehabilitation work on the Yamuna floodplains as per the proposed plan and directions issued by the NGT from time to time. "We have not altered the responsibilities entrusted to the DDA concerning the management or rehabilitation of the Yamuna floodplains, in any manner," the court clarified.

The NGT had directed the foundation to deposit ₹5 crore with the DDA to be utilised for the restoration of the floodplains of the Yamuna.

In its judgment, the top court said the NGT had failed to note that the floodplain, which was the site of the event, was already in a damaged condition prior to its handing over to the foundation.

The court said the NGT did not even consider relevant material, including a letter from the foundation regarding the presence of debris and construction material at the site.

police complaint, saying that the Agriculture College and Research Centre at Kawardha received an email at 8.41 a.m., in which it was claimed that the paper had leaked. Other officials received the email at 8.54 a.m.

The complaint added that students and their representatives also informed the university through WhatsApp that some purported questions from the paper were circulating.

Based on the complaint, a case was registered against unidentified persons under the Chhattisgarh Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2008, and Section 316 (criminal breach of trust) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023.

A team of more than 100 police personnel, including members of the Anti-Crime and Cyber Unit as well as personnel from the Telibandha police station, was formed to probe the paper leak.

Business

Trade scam or supply chain play? Profit in transit

Data and industry sources reveal little Chinese ownership of such pumps/components sent to the U.S. by Indian/India-based firms; many are large U.S. multinationals with global production centers, they are typically listed in the New York Stock Exchange and follow sourcing strategies that give them cost and technology advantage; profits go to their shareholders or reinvested for growth

M. Kalyanaraman
M. Soundariya Preetha
CHENNAI

The "Great Transshipment Scam", an August 2026 White House report, accuses India's Pune-Gujarat-Chennai production belt of pumps and compressors that export to the U.S. as being largely just pit stops in the movement of Chinese goods to America where no meaningful value addition is made. The report says China-linked exporters use jurisdictions like India for "both limited production activity and logistics-side routing".

Pressor manufacturing in Cincinnati, Dayton and Columbus. Pune-Gujarat-Chennai are the "ugly sister cities" that have replaced the industrial belts in the three U.S. cities mentioned before, as per the report.

An Indian pump draws a tariff of 10% while entering the U.S. One coming from China attracts 10% to 25-35% as per Section 301, which the Trump administration slapped on China in its first term for alleged IP theft, discriminatory business practices, forced technology transfer and so on. The report alleges that ever since Section 301 started applying to China, imports from China have dipped but imports from other countries such as India, Mexico and Vietnam have gone up at exactly the same rate and volume, which the U.S. government has interpreted as inference of a "transshipment scam."

Parsing of figures and speaking to industry sources, however, reveals that there is little Chinese ownership of such pumps/components sent to the U.S. by Indian/India-based companies. Many are large U.S. multinationals with global production centers. They are typically listed in the New York Stock Exchange and follow sourcing strategies that give them cost and technology advantages. The profits of these American companies go to their shareholders or reinvested for growth.

Sourcing strategies are complex and navigate cheap raw materials and manufacturing, tariff differential and geopolitics to cut costs. For instance, an American pump company with a plant in India recently purchased two branded motors from Singapore under India's Advantage Authorisation scheme that allows duty-free import of raw

Pointing fingers

The White House report calls Pune-Gujarat-Chennai belt 'ugly sister-cities' that have damaged local production of pumps and compressors in the Ohio sister cities of Cincinnati, Dayton and Columbus

India, Mexico, Vietnam, China, Taiwan, Italy and Canada are the biggest suppliers of pumps to the U.S.

The White House report calls out that India, Mexico and Vietnam are recyclers of Chinese pumps and compressors without doing significant value addition



materials and components needed to make products for export. This company exports its products across the globe, including the U.S. An Indian pump manufacturing company in the small and medium-scale (SME) category exports pumpsets, including to the U.S. Since the parts for these pumps are not available in India, it imports them from China, paying Indian Customs Du-

ty, potentially nullifying tariff differential.

And this is a global phenomenon. A reliable industry report that tracked HS Code 8413 imports to the U.S. from across the world barring leaders - China, Taiwan and Italy - shows that some 85% of the import value comes from Canada, which is not on the list of dubious nations in the White House report. Mexico comes next with

more than 11% while India comes third contributing a little over 2% and Brazil and Vietnam are fourth and fifth with much less than 1%. Out of the top 50 suppliers, 16 are U.S. firms, among the most well-known OEMs of pumps. Six are German-owned and they too are blue-chip firms. Four are Japanese, 3 South Korean and 1 each Swiss, UK, Chinese, Hong Kong and so on.

There are five Indian firms in the top 50. Two are Mexican. The industry report puts the total value of Indian pump exports to the U.S. at some \$4,000 crore. Industry sources say only a fraction of this comes from Indian companies.

Govt. action sought

While the White House report attempts to locate holes in the global manufacturing maze and brands them as "shadow" operations whose only motive is tariff evasion, it also makes

Indian MSME manufacturers vulnerable to damaging action by the U.S. government. Their factories have been around for years and have collaborated with international partners for technology so they could meet American standards to cater to that market.

"The US already applies strict non-preferential origin rules based on substantial transformation. Yet the report says these rules remain complex, inconsistent and open to misuse, and calls for tougher statutory standards. This could increase uncertainty and compliance costs for legitimate manufacturers using imported inputs without necessarily improving the detection of deliberate customs fraud," says Ajay Srivastava of Global Trade Research Initiative.

"Pumps sold in the U.S. market should meet mandatory standards and norms and we spent years to design pump-

sets to meet these requirements. We cannot sell these pumpsets in other countries as they are designed specifically for the U.S. The design and voltage are different for the American buildings or agricultural market. India is competitive to China in forgings and castings and Indian companies will not pay Customs duties to import the pumps here to supply to the U.S. as this is not an economically viable option," says an Indian pump exporter.

A loophole

Industry sources find the possibilities of some firms in India doing third country invoicing and shipping directly from China to the U.S. This too is an age-old practice in global trade. But, the White House report is specifically on goods landing in India and leaving without major value addition.

INBRIEF



'\$72.85 bn forex inflows via FCNR (B), OFCB, ECB Swap'

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Saturday said that \$72.85 billion (\$7,848 million) of foreign exchange has been generated via FCNR(B) Deposits, External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs) and Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs) under the Reserve Bank Swap facility as on August 21, 2026. The position of forex inflows as reported by Authorised Dealer Banks to the RBI till August 21, 2026 includes \$64.40 billion by way of FCNR (B) deposits; \$4.86 billion via OFCBs and \$2.59 billion by ECBs.

'SEBI reviewing framework for disclosure of issue proceeds utilisation'

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Market regulator SEBI is reviewing the framework for monitoring and disclosing utilisation of issue proceeds to improve timely disclosures and streamline the compliance process, SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kant Pandey said on Saturday.



Tuhin Kant Pandey

Addressing the Institute of Directors' Annual Directors' Conclave 2026, Mr. Pandey said transparency is not merely about the volume of information disclosed by a company but about whether the information helps investors understand what matters. "We are reviewing the framework for monitoring and disclosure of utilisation of issue proceeds, with the objective of improving timely disclosures and streamlining the compliance process," Mr. Pandey said. He said a company making a disclosure does not necessarily mean it has become transparent.

"True transparency is not the volume of information. It is the quality, timeliness and usefulness of information," the SEBI chairman said.

Mr. Pandey said the regulator has progressively strengthened the frame-

FSSAI issues 150 notices to food firms over misleading ads

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Food regulator FSSAI on Saturday informed that it has issued 150 notices to food companies, including major brands Nestle India, PepsiCo and Coca-Cola India, in recent months over misleading advertisements, false claims and non-compliance with labelling regulations.

In a social media post, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) shared an update on its enforcement action taken against major brands in recent months.

"Over 150 notices issued for misleading advertisements, false claims & labelling non-compliances," the FSSAI said.

Major brands

The regulator shared the list of a few major brands against whom action has been taken. These include Nestle India Ltd., Red Bull India, Danone India, Monster Energy India Pvt. Ltd., Hell Energy Pvt. Ltd., Mondelez India, Coca-Cola India, Diageo, Pernod Ricard, and Kenvue Inc.

In the past few months, the FSSAI said it has taken action against various food business operators (FBOs) for serious violations of its laws and regulations.

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India remains a very attractive destination for global investments and its economic fundamentals form the basis for strong investor confidence, Jyoti Jeetun, the Minister of Finance and Economic Planning of Mauritius told *The Hindu* in an interview.

Ms. Jeetun added that the amended Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement (DTAA) between the two countries, which was recently ratified by the Mauritian Cabinet, would ensure that genuine and constructive investments flow from Mauritius to India.

She also said that whatever concerns investors had with the amendments

to the DTAA have now been ironed out.

Mauritius has historically been a major source of investments into India. It accounted for about \$6.65 billion or 11.2% of the total foreign direct investment (FDI) that entered India in 2025-26, the second-highest that year after Singapore, according to data from the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT).

Between April 2000 and March 2026, Mauritius accounted for \$186 billion of FDI, which is nearly a quarter of the total inward FDI during that period.

"India remains a very attractive destination for global investment flows," Ms. Jeetun said. "As one of the world's top four economic powers, India's primary



Jyoti Jeetun

economic ambition is to become a \$5 trillion economy by fiscal year 2028-2029. This ambition underscores the scale of capital it will require to grow its economy," she added.

"India's fundamentals, its vast market size, ongoing reforms, and rapid digital transformation continue to underpin strong investor confidence."

Plugging gaps

While Mauritius has been a

major source of FDI into India, there have been some concerns that a large part of these investments are not genuinely from Mauritius and that companies were using its tax treaty with India to route investments through shell companies simply located in Mauritius but that did not actually do business there. The tax authorities on both sides have over the years tried to plug these gaps.

The India-Mauritius DTAA was signed in 1982 has historically played an important role in facilitating investment into India through Mauritius. Ms. Jeetun explained, adding that it has been pivotal for Mauritius' economic partnership with India for four decades.

"The 2016 Protocol introduced source-based taxation of capital gains on shares acquired on or after 1 April 2017, whereby India was allowed to impose a capital gains tax," she said. "A change in FDI flow from Mauritius to India has been observed. Mauritius moved from being the leading source of FDI into India to generally ranking among the second or third largest sources."

Then, in 2024, the agreement was further amended to introduce the Principal Purpose Test (PPT). This basically said that, if the principal purpose of setting up a company or passing investment flows through Mauritius is to receive tax benefits, then India can refuse to provide those tax benefits.

This amendment was signed by the previous government in Mauritius in March 2024. However, due to concerns raised by investors on both sides, it was ratified by the Mauritian Cabinet of the new government only in July 2026. Ms. Jeetun explained how the Indian tax authorities had cooperated with Mauritius to iron out the various concerns and issues.

The amendment still needs to be notified by both sides before it can come into effect.

"Since we assumed office in November 2024, we have through diplomatic channels engaged with the Indian authorities to bring certain clarity and restore the trust and certainty for investors," she said.

CENTRE FOR MATERIALS FOR ELECTRONICS TECHNOLOGY (C-MET)
(Scientific Society, Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), Govt of India)
Panchawati, Off. Dr. Homi Bhabha Road, Pashan, Pune-411 008, India

CORRIGENDUM 1: Extension of submission of EOI responses for DCP for the project on photonic packaging (A-PACK)

Please refer to the EOI call CMET/PUNE/2026-27/PIC/01 dated 5th Aug 2026 on the web page www.cmet.gov.in

In this connection, it has been decided to revise the last date of submission of proposals for EOI and the date for opening and other activities. The revised dates are as given below:

Particulars	Original Date	Revised Date
Last date of submission of EOI responses	23.08.2026	28.08.2026
Opening of EOI responses	25.08.2026	31.08.2026
Declaration of shortlisted Firms	31.08.2026	4.09.2026

All other conditions remain the same. Proposers are advised to submit the responses in advance. CMET, Pune will not be responsible for any delay in submission of responses within the time mentioned above

Sd/-
In-charge Administration

TRANVACORE DEVASOM BOARD
Devasom Commissioner Office
Nanthancode, Thiruvananthapuram - 695 003
E-mail: dcotdb@gmail.com Ph: 918991411

ROC No: 26/2026/SAB 22-08-2026

Re E-Tender Notice for Sabarimala

Competitive Re e-tenders are invited from experienced manufacturers, distributors, and contractors through <https://tenders.kerala.gov.in> for the supply of required materials for the preparation and distribution of offering Prasadams (Vazhipada Prasadam) in connection with Mandala-Makaravilakku, Media Visthu, Monthly Poojas, and other requirements for the year 1202 ME (2026-2027) at Sabarimala, Pamba and Nilakkal Devasom under the Travancore Devasom Board.

Details are listed below:

Sl.No	Item Required	Quantity	EMD
A Category			
1.	Powdered Jaggery	5,000 MT	10,00,000/-
2.	250 ML Paper container (Ring & Lid-Type)	75,000	1,00,000/-
B Category			
3.	Dried Rice	1,400 MT	2,00,000/-
4.	Dry Ginger	40 MT	40,000/-
5.	Dry Ginger Powder	3 MT	10,000/-
6.	Cumin Seeds	20 MT	30,000/-
7.	Butter Paper Bag	80,00,000 Nos.	1,00,000/-
8.	Ghee Pouch	1000 Kilogram	10,000/-
9.	BOP Tape	2000 Nos	5,000/-
10.	Flattened Rice/Avai (Pamba)	4 MT	5,000/-

Submission starting date : 23-08-2026, 10.00 AM
Re E-Tender closing date : 28-08-2026, 10.00 AM
Re E-Tender opening date : 29-08-2026, 10.00 AM

• More details and conditions are available at our website
www.travancoredevasomboard.org
• All tender processing - related queries will be entertained only online.
Sd/- Devasom Commissioner

மத்திய சித்த மருத்துவ ஆராய்ச்சிக் குழுமம்
(ஆயுர் அமைச்சகம், இந்திய அரசு)
தில்லி-6, எ.எம். தாம்பம் என்.பி.ரோடும், சென்னை-600047.

केंद्रीय सिद्ध अनुसन्धान परिषद्
(आयुर्वेद विभाग, भारत सरकार)
जो.ए.स.टी. रोड, नंदारम सानटोरियम, चेन्नई-600047.

CENTRAL COUNCIL FOR RESEARCH IN SIDDHA
(Ministry of Ayush, Govt. of India)
GST Road, Tambaram Sanatorium, Chennai - 600 047.
Phone: 044-2621 2421, 2621 1621,
e-mail: ccrs-ayush@gov.in, Website: www.ccrs.ayush.gov.in

Advertisement No. 08/2026

Central Council for Research in Siddha (CCRS), invites applications for the following positions for various Contractual positions:

Sl. No	Name of Position	Number of Posts	Place of posting
1.	Domain Expert (Siddha)	01	CCRS, HQ., Chennai / Peripheral Institutes / Units.
2.	Media Consultant	01	CCRS, HQ., Chennai.
3.	Consultant (Admin)	03	SCRU Bengaluru, SCRUB New Delhi & SCRUB Goa.
4.	Research Associate (Chemistry)	01	CCRS, HQ., Chennai.
5.	Field Attendant	01	SMGP & RC, Mettur.

Last date of submission of application is 11.09.2026. Further details regarding eligibility, educational qualifications, age, experience, remuneration, tenure of contract and other terms and conditions etc, are followed in the Council's website: www.ccrs.ayush.gov.in.

Date: 23.08.2026 Director General, CCRS.

Government of Odisha
"e" procurement Notice No-03
PH. No. 0674-2540603, E-mail: senhonorth.bbsr@rediffmail.com
Identification No.03/CCE NH, NORTHERN OF 2026-27

Sl. No.	Name of the Work	Value of Work (Rs. in lakh)	Period of completion (in calendar months)	Last date / Time for receipt of bids	Date of opening of tender	Name and address of the officer inviting tender
01	Providing, fixing and installation of Solar Street Lights within Km. 17560 to 21000 Km. (Brahmapur Town) on NH-316 in the State of Odisha for the year 2026-27.	119.11	03 (Three)	17.09.2026 upto 17.30 hours.	18.09.2026 at 15.30 hours	Chief Construction Engineer, O/o the Chief Construction Engineer, Northern NH Circle, Unit-4X (F&T), Bhubaneswar-752002.

02. Further details can be seen from the "e" procurement website www.tendersodisha.gov.in with effect from 10.00 hours of 22.08.2026.

03. Addendum / Corrigendum / Cancellation of tender if required shall be hosted in the aforesaid website only.

04. The authority reserves the right to cancel any / all bids without assigning any reason.

Chief Construction Engineer, Northern N.H.Circle, Bhubaneswar.
NPCR-34001/34188/126-27/0002
34001/167/2627

SCIENCE

'Indian rock yields oldest directly dated traces of microbial life'

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Researchers say they have found "compelling evidence" from multiple sources that microbial life existed in what is now eastern India at least 3.5 billion years ago. Typically, these involve finding fossils or traces of organic chemicals but in this case they rely on converging chemical clues, according to a paper that appeared in the peer-reviewed *Proceedings of the*

National Academy of Sciences.

The source of discovery is a single carbon-bearing rock in the Singhbhum Craton, which is an ancient, stable block of continental crust in eastern India, spanning parts of Jharkhand and Odisha. It has long interested geologists because it holds some of the oldest rocks in India, recording crust that formed more than 4 billion years ago.

"To our knowledge,

(this) is the oldest directly dated rock with a confirmed biosignature," say the authors, who include Trisrota Chaudhuri, of the Geological Survey of India, Kolkata, and Mark Harrison, of the Department of Earth, Planetary, and Space Sciences, University of California, Los Angeles.

The rock – a "black-and-white" banded chert from Bhitardari – pairs a firm age with several independent chemical and structural signs that its carbon

was made by living organisms. Chert is a hard, fine-grained rock made largely of silica that can preserve organic matter for billions of years, but cannot be dated directly. So the researchers extracted zircons – hardy crystals that act like natural clocks as they trap uranium that decays to lead at a known rate. Of eight zircons analysed, four indicated an age of 3,497 million years. Because those zircons appear to be volcanic ash that

settled as the chert formed, the team took that to be the rock's age, too.

They then argued the carbon was biological. Its balance of carbon isotopes matches carbon captured by living cells. They also found the material was degraded organic matter rather than later inorganic contamination.

Scientists bother with such questions because the earth formed about 4.54 billion years ago, so a 3.5-billion-year-old trace of

life comes from only about a billion years after the planet's birth and may open new hypotheses on evolution. If microbes were already established, life itself must have begun earlier still. That bears on whether life is a freak accident or something that emerges readily on habitable worlds.

Older claims exist, including graphite in 3.7- to 3.8-billion-year-old Greenland rocks, but several have been disputed.

SNAPSHOTS



Narwhal tusk is unique thanks to its double twist

The narwhal tusk is nature's sole straight tusk, and scientists now know how it gets its left-handed twist. X-ray images of the tusk's building blocks, the microscopic collagen fibrils, revealed two layers: the outer layer twists to the left and the inner layer to the right. The opposing twists create an internal tension, allowing the tusk to grow straight and strong. The detail could help scientists learn how tissues integrate such patterns to acquire certain mechanical properties.



Psychedelics 'embed' people more in their environs

Scientists have thought psychedelics disorganised brain signals. A study has disagreed. Analysing brain scans of 62 adults, researchers found psilocybin caused brain activity to align closer with a person's environment (e.g. listening to music), a state they called embeddedness, which could be why many people feel a sense of being at one with their surroundings. The stronger this alignment, the more the person's mood improved later, suggesting it is key to psychedelics' therapeutic benefits.



Diamond stays diamond even at extreme pressure

By crushing diamond samples with shock waves reaching 1 terapascal, about 10-million-times the atmospheric pressure, scientists have found that rather than shift into different crystal structures, they stay intact before melting into a metallic liquid. This revealed that as the pressure increased, diamond's melting point dropped slightly. The data can help scientists understand the interiors of giant planets and refine nuclear fusion setups that use diamond components.

Retractions alone do not protect India's scientific record

Scholars agree that the way retractions happen at present raise thorny challenges to preserving the integrity of the scientific record; experts said when a retraction can be said to have achieved its purpose is itself 'very difficult' to say

Rohan Singh
LUCKNOW

Once a journal publishes a research paper, other researchers can keep citing that work and build on it to produce more research. Sometimes, this continues even after the journal has retracted the original paper because it contains a mistake or, as is increasingly the case, it was produced by fraudulent means.

So simply withdrawing a faulty paper does not correct the research record; the work based on it also needs to be checked and, if necessary, undone.

According to Sabuj Bhattacharyya, an expert on research ethics at the Institute for Stem-cell Science and Regenerative Medicine, Bengaluru, retractions have increased substantially over the last four decades. In 2025, his team analysed data on life-sciences papers retracted between 1981 and 2023 and found that the reasons for retraction included non-compliance with ethical standards, plagiarism, data-related concerns, and publication misconduct.

In a 2026 study, research scholar P.R. Devanath and associate professor Rupesh Kumar of Tumkur University, Karnataka, analysed more than 12,000 citations of papers funded by the Indian government and later retracted. They found that 30% of the citations had been incurred after a paper was retracted. They also identified a "cascading retraction effect" in which some

Vitiated record

The way retractions happen today frustrate the integrity of the scientific record

- Research retractions have increased significantly over the last few years thanks to higher publication volumes and scrutiny
- Withdrawing a faulty paper does not correct the record because subsequent studies may continue citing the original work
- Many researchers remain unaware of retractions because journals often fail to notify institutions and authors avoid discussion
- Experts said the scientific system should learn from retractions to improve data sharing and institutional accountability
- Artificial intelligence systems may also propagate retracted findings unless they are specifically updated to flag errors
- The scientific record may remain permanently uncorrected if no researchers bother to replicate and fix retracted studies

There is no foolproof way to ensure researchers are quickly informed when a paper is retracted.

LUCAS VASQUES/UNSPLASH

retracted papers continued to be cited by studies that were themselves later retracted. Nearly 64% of those second-generation papers were also authored by the same groups.

Not all post-retraction citations necessarily endorsed the retracted findings, but many also did not acknowledge the paper's retracted status. Some retracted papers also continued to appear in patents. Dr. Devanath said one important reason is a lack of awareness, particularly among early-career researchers with limited training in responsible citation practices.

Retraction is part of how science corrects itself – but the correction often comes long after a paper has entered the scientific literature, according to Partha Pratim Majumder, former National Science Chair with the Science and

Engineering Research Board. By the time a study is withdrawn, other researchers may have built on its findings. He said there is no foolproof way to ensure researchers are quickly informed when a paper is retracted.

Bhaskar Mukherjee, professor and head, Department of Library and Information Science, Banaras Hindu University, also said retractions often receive little institutional attention in India. So journals rarely notify an author's institution while researchers themselves often avoid discussing retracted papers.

Gagandeep Kang, adjunct professor of microbiology at the Christian Medical College, Vellore, said better communication alone is not enough. The more important question is whether the scientific system learns from each

retraction. A reactive system, she says, removes a problem paper but does little to understand why it passed scientific scrutiny in the first place.

She added that a stronger research integrity system would identify whether the problem was fraud, an honest error or failure of replication – and use those lessons to make peer review, data-sharing practices, and institutional accountability better.

Mr. Devanath and Prof. Kumar also recommended dedicated research support offices, checks for retracted references during peer review, and regular training in responsible research practices.

That said, ever-stronger research practices may not resolve the problem. Achal Agrawal, founder of the independent research-integrity effort India Research Watch, said that as AI sys-

tems increasingly draw on published research, retracted studies may continue to influence AI-generated responses unless those models are also updated to flag retracted papers.

Scholars agree that the way retractions happen at present also raises thorny challenges to preserving the integrity of the scientific record.

In fact, Dr. Majumder said when a retraction can be said to have achieved its purpose is itself "very difficult" to determine. A retraction is meant to inform other scientists that the data and inferences reported in a study are incorrect. Because that information spreads slowly, he said he believes a retraction will have broadly achieved its purpose when about 90% of researchers in that field are aware of it, although complete awareness is impossible to ensure.

"When errors in science are inadvertent, the errors get corrected when the experiment is repeated by the scientist who committed the error or by another scientist. Thereafter, the erroneous results of the experiment do not influence scientific practice," Dr. Majumder said. That process, however, may never occur in every case. According to Dr. Majumder, no scientist may be willing to study the same problem addressed in a retracted paper and generate correct data and inferences. "Therefore," he added, "the scientific record may never be corrected."

(Rohan Singh is an independent science journalist in Lucknow)

New studies pursue 'perfect' blend for coffee and health



SPEAKING OF SCIENCE
D. Balasubramanian

Every morning, many of us drink one or two cups of coffee and feel good, re-freshed, and ready for the day. Some of us drink one or two more cups at work before lunchtime. Some use pure coffee while others add chicory to it. We prepare the powder using a filter, add milk and sugar, and take a swig.

While many Indians have a fondness for coffee, almost everyone in the U.S. and Europe drinks coffee, and more of it, every day.

Now, what are the effects of drinking coffee? How many cups per day? Should it be black coffee or can it include milk and su-

gar? And how does this affect our health? These are some questions that have been on our minds – and for which research has offered contradictory answers in the past. Fortunately, a new publication, titled 'Caffeine and Cardiovascular Disease: A Scientific Statement from the American Heart Association', may clear some doubts. The authors of the statement analysed several studies that examined the effects of caffeine, the active molecule in coffee that stimulates the brain and the central nervous system and encourages the body to produce and use more energy.

The statement reported that moderate caffeine intake, especially through coffee, may lower the risks of type-2 diabetes, stroke, heart failure, and atrial fibrillation. However, high



While many Indians have a fondness for coffee, almost everyone in the U.S. and Europe drinks it every day. MIKE KENNELLY

doses, especially from energy drinks, may harm cardiovascular health, and unfiltered coffee can also raise LDL cholesterol levels.

Data from the Nurses' Health Study at the Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health and Harvard Medical School and an analysis of 3 lakh people from the U.K. Biobank and Health Canada have indi-

cated that drinking four cups a day may lower the risk of developing cancer, type-2 diabetes, heart diseases, and age-related disorders like dementia and Alzheimer's disease. However, analyses also suggest that it would be prudent for pregnant and lactating women to limit their coffee intake to three cups a day.

Drinking hot black coffee is recommended, with little or no additives like sugar or milk. However, a group from Copenhagen, Denmark, pointed out in the *Journal of Agricultural and Food Science* in 2023 that adding milk to black coffee can be good, as milk contains antioxidants, minerals, and vitamins and allays the bitter taste.

Many people in South India prefer to have pure coffee, i.e. with no additives like chicory, which comes from a perennial herb plant with coloured flowers. This herb contains no caffeine but a polysaccharide called inulin, which supports digestion and can help control blood sugar.

The benefits of a coffee and chicory blend and their implications for nutrition and health implications were discussed in a recent review paper by a

group led by Pushpa S. Murthy at the Central Food Technology and Research Institute, Mysuru, published in the *Journal of Food Science and Technology*. Chicory contains several compounds that help protect the liver from inflammation, shield the stomach from damage, and may help defend against cancer. Adding chicory to coffee also improves coffee's fragrance and taste.

The optimal blend of coffee and chicory was suggested to be 70:30 or 60:40, coffee to chicory, to strike a balance between taste and benefits. In fact, most coffee sellers across India have these ratios, unless of course, a customer asks for 'pure' coffee. This writer himself used to prefer pure coffee until he read the review article by the Mysuru group!

dbala@ltpi.org



Question Corner

Ones of a kind

Why do only humans look different from each other?

– Mahua Ray

Humans are one of the species whose individual differences are unusually obvious to humans. We can be told apart by skin colour, hair colour, facial proportions, body shape, height, and many other traits. Our brains also excel at processing faces.

However, we are also very bad at distinguishing individuals of species we don't interact with. We can tell two cats apart but not two sparrows, say. But sparrows – and birds and most animals in general – can recognise individual members of their own

species, e.g. using differences in plumage or calls.

Humans can also learn how. After years spent studying chimpanzees, scientists' ability to perceive differences becomes honed to the differences that already exist between individuals. The same goes for other animals. Individual plants of the same species can also have different height, branching patterns, leaf shapes, colours, etc. However, plants lack the evolutionary pressure to advertise their individual identities the way social animals do.

Readers may send their questions/answers to science@thehindu.co.in

What does ChatGPT for Teens entail?

Why did OpenAI launch this? What are its features? What restrictions does it have? Can it be used for learning?

Abhinaya K.

The story so far:

On August 18, OpenAI launched a version of ChatGPT for teenagers. The company said ChatGPT for Teens will have stronger protections, including restrictions on content related to self-harm, suicide, and sexual content. The launch comes amid claims that AI chatbots have contributed to deaths by suicide among the youth and caused other mental health problems.

What are the key features of ChatGPT for Teens?

ChatGPT for Teens, designed for 13- to 17-year-olds, has features such as parental controls, quiet hours, a study mode, and notifications for situations that require real-world interventions. Most of these safeguards were already present in accounts for minors. Apart from those who identify themselves as minors, OpenAI has said that it will also automatically place users who its system determines to be below the age of 17 under ChatGPT for Teens. The company says it is guided by a commitment to treat teens as teens, and to encourage real-world support.

Apart from restrictions on content related to self-harm, violence, eating disorders, dangerous activities, and explicit sexual or graphic material, it also places emphasis on helping teens study, rather than providing answers.

Apart from restrictions on content related to self-harm, violence, eating disorders, and sexual or graphic material, it also places emphasis on helping teens study, rather than providing answers

Can ChatGPT for Teens be used for learning?

As the first generation of children and teens grows up with AI, an increasing number of them uses the tool for

learning. ChatGPT for Teens promises to support students working on their lessons. For example, a teen attempting to solve a mathematical equation will not be directly given the answer; instead, the chatbot will go over the equation step-by-step, ask questions, and give hints for solutions.

The study mode, built with inputs from teachers, scientists, and other experts, will use this detailed approach to arrive at answers. Parents and teens can even set specific timings for it to be enabled by default.

What other guardrails are present?

The company says ChatGPT for Teens will “reduce exposure to harmful content while preserving the ability to learn, create, and explore”. The accounts of parents and teens can be linked, and parents can receive notifications in certain high-risk situations. This will alert them if something may be seriously wrong. The alerts will be monitored by human moderators.

OpenAI will also provide options such as quiet hours that regulate when ChatGPT can’t be used, turning off memory so it doesn’t save and use chats while responding, and removing options for image generation.

For teens, the chatbot will offer periodic reminders to take breaks from using ChatGPT and caution them against uploading sensitive images. It will also provide the option of switching off voice mode to minimise the ability of the chatbot to appear like a person.

“ChatGPT should not use romantic language, encourage emotional dependence, or imply that it has feelings or consciousness,” OpenAI said.

However, the effectiveness of these safeguards remains to be seen. Experts have reservations on whether these actions will be enough to address the dependence of users on chatbots.

Why is this needed?

Concerns over the unchecked use of AI chatbots have been mounting for a while now. There have been several news reports of teens and adults using chatbots for advice on self-harm and/or inflicting violence on others. Several families, including the parents of 16-year-old Adam Raine, who died by suicide last year, have used OpenAI saying it has contributed to deaths.

There have also been growing concerns about learning losses due to the use of these chatbots. Various studies have highlighted the harm that chatbots cause to critical-thinking skills. Among teens, this can cause lasting damage.

The ability of chatbots to mimic human characteristics and emotions has also led to several users forming relationships with them. OpenAI CEO Sam Altman has spoken about how several people, particularly the youth, have an “emotional over-reliance” on ChatGPT.

Governments are also facing pressure to regulate the use of AI chatbots. The U.S. Federal Trade Commission is examining the negative impacts of AI chatbots acting as companions, particularly on children and teens. The U.K. is considering restricting the use of AI chatbots for users under 18. India does not have stand-alone legislation regulating how children use AI chatbots.

Those in distress or having suicidal thoughts are encouraged to seek help and counselling by calling ICALL 05129 87821

What are the U.S.’s latest allegations against India?

Why has the U.S. accused India of violating what it considers fair trade practices? How many countries have been named in The Great Transshipment Scam? What do these allegations mean for India? Can they impact India’s growth story?

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan

The story so far:

Last week, the U.S. accused India of violating what it considers fair trade practices. The White House published a report titled “The Great Transshipment Scam” in which it accused about 40 countries, including India, of helping China evade U.S. tariffs.

What is the Great Transshipment Scam?

Over the last nearly three decades, the U.S. and Chinese economies have become deeply intertwined, with the U.S. increasingly relying on China to be its manufacturing hub, and China relying on the U.S. as its market and for investments. This is a somewhat simplistic assessment of their engagement, but it is also the most relevant for the current context.

This relationship has resulted in the U.S. running huge trade deficits with China. That is, importing much more from the country than it exports to it. U.S. President Donald Trump has for long spoken about his concerns with vast trade deficits; it is primarily why he insisted on levying tariffs on U.S. trade partners during his second term.

However, China began facing such actions during Mr. Trump’s first term itself. In 2018, the U.S. imposed tariffs ranging from 7.5% to 100% on goods from China such as electric vehicles, semiconductors, and medical products under Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974, for unfair trade and tech practices. As per the White

The U.S. has alleged that more than 40 countries or regions are importing Chinese goods, modifying them, and exporting them to the U.S. at tariffs below what they would have faced had they directly been exported from China

House report, this resulted in a shrinking of the U.S.’s trade deficit with China in 2019 and 2020. On July 24, 2026, the U.S. added a further 12.5% tariff for gaps in forced-labour compliance and the lack of comprehensive legal import prohibitions.

According to the report, since 2018, Chinese exporters have increasingly been routing goods through third countries to evade tariffs. “Products that previously moved directly from China to the United States were shipped through jurisdictions where limited assembly, finishing, repackaging, relabeling, or documentation changes could create the appearance of a different national origin,” the report stated.

What is India’s involvement?

The White House has identified more than 40 countries associated with “elevated illegal transshipment risk”, with India among the top “enablers” of China’s evasion of tariffs. The other countries/regions named as the top enablers are Mexico, Canada, the European Union, Japan, and South Korea.

The U.S. has alleged that these countries are importing Chinese goods, modifying them marginally, and exporting them to the U.S. at tariffs below what these goods would have faced had they directly been exported from China. This, the report said, has led to significant revenue loss for the U.S. government.

“The Office of Trade and Economic Analysis estimates that approximately \$67 billion in U.S.-bound goods were transshipped from China through the top hubs – Mexico, India, and Vietnam – in 2025, producing an estimated \$28 billion in lost tariff revenue,” the report said.

As an example, the report mentioned the Pune-Gujarat-Chennai production belt, saying that the region “absorbs” pumps and compressors from China, thereby affecting industrial supply chains in Cincinnati, Dayton, and Columbus in the U.S.

What does this mean for the U.S.?

Broadly, the report’s findings suggest that the U.S.’s tariff policy has failed to reduce U.S. imports and increase domestic production. While U.S. imports from China fell from \$525.8 billion in 2017 to \$327.5 billion in 2025, total U.S. imports from all countries rose sharply from \$2.41 trillion to \$3.50 trillion. In short, the U.S. replaced many Chinese finished goods with imports from other countries rather than with domestically produced goods.

As Ajay Srivastava, founder of the think tank



U.S. President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping during a state dinner at the Great Hall of the People in Beijing, AP

What did Trump say about India’s voting system?

Why is the President pushing for stricter voter ID rules in the U.S.? How are elections conducted in the U.S. and how are they different from those in India? What is the SAVE America Act? What do Americans think about the requirement of a photo ID?

Srinivasan Ramani

The story so far:

U.S. President Donald Trump posted on his social media platform, Truth Social, that India’s Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar had asked his administration how elections are held in the U.S. without a valid photo identity card. He also pointed out that just 1% of India’s 64.64 crore electors who voted in the last general elections voted by mail (unlike the large number who do so in the U.S.). Mr. Trump reiterated his demand that Congress pass the Safeguard American Voter Eligibility (SAVE America) Act, which would require documentary proof of citizenship to register to vote in federal elections and a photo ID to cast a ballot, among other restrictions.

How are elections conducted in the U.S. and how do they differ from elections in India?

Article I, Section 4 of the U.S. Constitution (the Elections Clause) empowers the State legislatures to determine the “times, places, and manner” of federal elections even as it allows Congress to alter or make such regulations. There is no national election authority like the Election Commission of India. There is the Federal Election Commission, but it is only empowered to regulate campaign finance as registration, balloting, and counting are done by

The Bipartisan Policy Center in the U.S. estimates that over 20 million eligible American citizens do not have ready access to a passport or a birth certificate. Newly registering young adults have also faced problems producing these documents

the States’ county and municipal jurisdictions. This is due to the strongly federal nature of the U.S., unlike India’s quasi-federal system.

The U.S. Congress also passed the National Voter Registration Act, 1993, which required States to offer voter registration at motor vehicle and public assistance offices, and the Help America Vote Act, 2002, which provided funding for States to buy new voting machines and called for State-wide elector databases.

Voter eligibility in the U.S. is therefore a State concern, and registration is elector-initiated. While documentary proof of citizenship is not demanded, a potential elector has to affirm citizenship under penalty of perjury on the registration form. Thirty-six States ask for some form of identification at the polling place and 23 ask for a photo ID.

This is unlike India, where electoral rolls are compiled in each State via house-to-house enumeration conducted by the ECI, which has superintendence over the whole process of registration. Eligible electors are then issued the Electoral Photo Identity Card (EPIC), though other documents, including Aadhaar, can be used as identification at the booth as well.

Is non-citizen voting a real problem in the U.S. as Mr. Trump has made it out to be?

Independent studies have found that almost all non-citizen registrations in the U.S. are accidental and only a small proportion of them votes. The Trump administration’s claims have not survived scrutiny. *The New York Times* reported that after announcing in July that it had identified 2,78,000 non-citizens on the rolls of four States, including 15,903 in Nevada, the Department of Homeland Security told Nevada’s election administrators this month that it had identified just 185 potential non-citizens so far. It described the earlier figure as a “ceiling” and shared a list without names.

Surveys show that a large majority of the electorate supports the requirement of photo identification at the polls. Yet, even this is short of the more onerous requirement of proving citizenship at the point of registration, which is what the SAVE America Act requires.

What is the SAVE America Act, and why is it opposed by Democrats and others?

The SAVE America Act was passed by the U.S.

Global Trade Research Initiative, said, “Mr. Trump’s tariffs changed the source of imports but failed to reduce America’s overall dependence on imported goods”.

What are the implications for India?

This is yet another way that the U.S. is finding fault with India’s trade policies. During his first term, Mr. Trump found fault with India’s tariffs on luxury motorcycles, after which India reduced them.

Last year, he blamed India for financing Russia’s war with Ukraine by importing Russian oil; his government hiked tariffs on imports from India to 50% as a penalty.

More recently, the U.S. Senate passed a Bill with Mr. Trump’s backing that would result in tariffs of up to 100% being levied on India for its Russian oil imports. The Bill is waiting to be introduced and passed in the House of Representatives.

Apart from this, the U.S. has also imposed a 10% tariff on imports from India as a penalty for not doing enough to curb the import of goods made using forced labour. Another investigation on excess capacity is ongoing, which could potentially see tariffs being hiked even further.

The latest allegations that India is helping China evade tariffs are not accompanied by penal actions yet, but that possibility remains. Mr. Trump could decide to impose further tariffs on countries he deems are helping China in this regard.

How could India’s economy be impacted?

For India, any penal action would be a blow to its growth story. Over the last few years, rather than predominantly importing Chinese finished goods, India has been importing raw materials and intermediate goods, using them to manufacture finished goods within the country, and then exporting them.

For example, electronic components made up 3.3% of India’s imports from China in the first quarter of 2015-16. This has grown to nearly 13% as of the first quarter of 2026-27. Several other goods used in manufacturing in India, such as electric machinery, chemicals, plastics, have seen their shares rise over the same period.

On the other hand, the share of finished goods such as telecom instruments have fallen from about 18% to 11% over the same period of time. Similarly, the share of manufactured fertilizers have fallen from about 7.5% in 2015 to less than 1% in 2026. The share of consumer electronics in imports from China have halved over the same period.

The “Make in India, For the World” story still relies heavily on inputs from China. If India is forced to curb those imports, its manufacturing costs will rise, making Indian products less competitive globally.

House of Representatives in February along party lines, with Republicans outnumbering Democrats. It requires every new registering elector or an existing elector who wants to update his/her record to produce a passport, or a birth certificate, or naturalisation papers along with a government photo ID. Mail-in voters – a widely used option in the U.S. – have to enclose a copy of their photo ID. States will then run names on electoral rolls through the U.S. Department of Homeland Security and the latter could flag non-citizens for removal. Election officials who register people who lack the documents can face up to five years in prison.

The Bipartisan Policy Center in the U.S. estimates that over 20 million eligible American citizens do not have ready access to a passport or a birth certificate. Newly registering young adults have also faced problems producing these documents. These concerns have led the Democratic Party to oppose the SAVE America Act, which has stalled in the Senate.

Is India’s Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process delivering the “pure” rolls that the ECI promises?

The SIR, launched by the ECI to “purify” the electoral rolls, uses a peculiar methodology in which electors must self-enumerate on forms distributed door-to-door by the ECI before being included in the draft roll. After scrutiny by election officials, who will compare the forms with the previous SIR conducted more than two decades ago in the States, the draft rolls will be updated (the corrections and clarifications phase) before new SIR rolls are released.

The three phases of the SIR conducted by the ECI have been beset by anomalies in each State. By phase 2 of the SIR, for instance, more than 7 crore names were deleted during the process. The issues with the SIR are reflected in the drastic fall in gender ratio in the new rolls across most States. In West Bengal, in particular, an analysis published in *The Hindu* showed that there has been a religious skew in the deletions as well, which mattered in the way the election results panned out in the State. Despite these infirmities and anomalies, the Supreme Court held that the exercise was well within the ECI’s statutory mandate.

The SIR in India has shifted the onus of verifying voter eligibility onto electors, unlike the earlier process in which election officials prepared the rolls by identifying and enrolling eligible citizens through house-to-house surveys. Opponents of the SAVE America Act have raised a similar concern about the Trump administration-backed legislation.

Attendees hold signs advocating for voting rights and against the SAVE America Act at a rally outside the U.S. Capitol in March in Washington, DC. APF



PROFILES

The man who steadied the ship

Mirza Fakhru Islam Alamgir

The former BNP general secretary who steered the party through the difficult years of the Hasina government, when Khaleda Zia was in jail and Tarique Rahman was in exile in the U.K., has been elected President of Bangladesh

Kallol Bhattacharjee

In 1961, General Ayub Khan's military government of Pakistan wanted to further entrench its control over East Pakistan and made the celebration of Rabindranath Tagore's birth centenary illegal. The crackdown had an opposite outcome as colleges and universities in East Pakistan erupted. The protests shaped a generation of leaders who would take important positions subsequently as Bangladesh became a free country a decade later. Mirza Fakhru Islam Alamgir, the new President of Bangladesh, graduated from Dhaka University during those early years when agrarian politics energised the demand for a new country.

There are many legends about Mr. Alamgir, one of which is that he is a master of marathon meetings, sustained simply by cups of tea. The late Khaleda Zia was also known for her energy and her tireless engagement with the cadre of the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP). But the only other person who used to spend longer hours at the BNP Chairperson's office in Dhaka's Gulshan was Mr. Alamgir. In 2015, one night, Begum Zia, on hearing that Mr. Alamgir was leaving the office at 2 a.m., chided him for working so late, as the Sheikh Hasina government had tightened political space and BNP leaders were under pressure. "They can detain you for plotting protests in the city if they find you without adequate party workers around," Begum Zia told him.

Among his friends and colleagues, President Alamgir is known for his personal bravery and integrity. G.M. Quader, younger brother of late President Gen. Ershad, who has known Mr. Alamgir for more than 50 years, says: "Sacrificing self-interest is rare in politics but Mirza Fakhru Islam Alamgir has sacrificed a lot for the BNP at a time when the party was under tremendous pressure. It was he who kept the party alive on the ground as Tarique Rahman lived in the U.K."

The period following the end of the last BNP government in 2006 was not

easy for the party or its cadre and officials. After the interim government, Ms. Hasina took charge in 2009, beginning an era in which the BNP remained under sustained pressure. During this period, it was Mr. Alamgir, the party's general secretary, who handled much of its political work. His emergence as President of Bangladesh marks the high point of a political career that has seen many of the highs and lows of Bangladesh's political history.

Starting as a student activist in East Pakistan, Mr. Alamgir was initially associated with the leftist student movement that opposed Gen. Ayub Khan's dictatorship. He was sent to study economics in Dhaka University where he joined the East Pakistan Students Union, the student wing of the Communist Party of Bangladesh.

His father, Mirza Ruhul Amin, had tried his luck with mainstream Pakistani politics and was elected to the provincial assembly.

By the end of the 1960s, with the political breakdown inside Pakistan, Mirza Ruhul Amin's career came to a standstill and he joined a peace committee in Thakurgaon to preserve local peace and amity as the Pakistan military attacked commoners. Eventually he too had to take refuge in India like many others because of the atrocities by the Pakistani forces.

During the 1971 war, Mr. Alamgir left Dhaka and went to Thakurgaon, and organised local resistance against Pakistani police and military forces.

Decades later, in 2018, in a video message against the Hasina-led government, Mr. Alamgir said he too had fought against the Pakistani forces like millions of other youngsters of Bangladesh.

Beginning of political career

Mr. Alamgir's active political career formally began when Gen. Ziaur Rahman took charge after the November 7, 1975 military uprising in Dhaka. Later, several leftist and socialist leaders joined Ziaur Rahman's political party, the BNP, and Mr. Alamgir was one of them. His first experience of working for a BNP



ILLUSTRATION: R. RAJESH

government came in 1979, when he served as secretary to Deputy Prime Minister S.A. Bari. He returned to teaching after the overthrow of the BNP government following the assassination of Ziaur Rahman in 1981.

During the next eight years, he taught economics in Dhaka and nurturing his links with the BNP that was being revived by Khaleda Zia. His father had reinvented his political career at this time and served as a Minister in the government of Hossein Mohammed Ershad. Mr. Alamgir left the government job towards the end of the 1980s when he won the chairmanship of the municipality of

Thakurgaon in 1988 as an Independent. He revived his links with the BNP once again in 1992 when Khaleda Zia was serving as PM.

He became a state Minister for agriculture in 2001 when Khaleda Zia became PM once again. He subsequently handled civil aviation and tourism as well. Mr. Alamgir came into national limelight during the difficult years of the BNP when Khaleda Zia was out of power and later in prison, and Tarique Rahman was forced into exile in the U.K. It was during this period, when Sheikh Hasina steered Bangladesh from 2009 onwards, that Mr. Alamgir took on

much of the party's responsibility.

In an interview with *The Hindu* in February this year, Mr. Alamgir, who was then in charge of the Ministry of Local Governance, Rural Development and Cooperatives, described the period under Ms. Hasina as "very difficult". "It was difficult for us personally but it was more difficult for our families as many of our party workers and leaders were jailed on multiple occasions during the Hasina years." On October 28, 2023, the BNP had given a call for a major rally in Dhaka that rattled the Hasina government. To scuttle the rally, the Awami League government detained him. The BNP boycotted the January 2024 election claiming that the government had rigged the polls and contesting in such circumstances was pointless. Following the overthrow of Ms. Hasina on August 5, 2024, Mr. Alamgir provided the BNP with the leadership it needed and took part in dialogues with the interim government aimed at stabilising the country.

The Hasina factor

Mr. Alamgir believes New Delhi should hand over Ms. Hasina to Dhaka. "We believe Hasina has really committed serious human rights violations. There is a popular demand to punish her and we believe that India should hand her over to us. But not handing over Sheikh Hasina to Bangladesh will not be a deterrent to build trade and commercial ties. We want to build even better ties," said Mr. Alamgir in February 2026.

G.M. Quader described Mr. Alamgir as a pragmatist who wants to build relations with important stakeholders such as India, and said the biggest test before him as the President of Bangladesh will be whether he can bring his pragmatic approach into politics and administration.

"Bangladesh's politics needs to be more inclusive as we need to discuss all challenges before the country in a transparent manner. Hopefully, as President of the country, Mirza Fakhru Islam Alamgir will be able to convince the government of Bangladesh to be just that," Mr. Quader told *The Hindu*.

THE GIST

Alamgir's active political career formally began when Gen. Ziaur Rahman took charge after the November 7, 1975 military uprising in Dhaka

His first experience of working for a BNP government came in 1979, when he served as the secretary to Deputy Prime Minister S.A. Bari

He became a state Minister for agriculture in 2001 when Khaleda Zia became PM, and subsequently handled civil aviation and tourism as well

The Islamic apparatchik

Mohsen Rezaee

A former IRGC commander and a close confidant of the Supreme Leader, the General has been appointed Secretary of the Supreme National Security Council

Stanly Johny

Some in Iran call him the "eternal candidate". Maj. Gen. Mohsen Rezaee, now 71, ran for President of Iran three times – 2009, 2013 and 2021. The former commander of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) has always remained an institutional insider and an ideologically committed apparatchik of the Islamic Republic, but, despite repeated attempts, he never managed to secure a position at the heart of Iran's strategic decision making apparatus. The war the U.S. and Israel launched against Iran on February 28, 2026 changed that. Mr. Rezaee is now one of the most important decision makers in war-hit Iran and a close confidant of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei.

In March, when Mojtaba was appointed the Supreme Leader after the assassination of his father and predecessor Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Mr. Rezaee was picked as the military adviser of the new leader. The country was under attack. A host of senior leaders were killed in the initial phase of the war – from Ali Khamenei to Ali Larijani, who was the Secretary of the Supreme National Security Council. Initially Mojtaba opted for replacements for the assassinated leaders and allowed the



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

system to function without any major shake-up. But earlier this month, he made a host of changes in the government by appointing his loyal supporters to key posts.

Ali Abdollahi was named the chief of staff of the armed forces; Ahmad Vahidi, the IRGC commander, was promoted to the rank of Major General; Ali Azmaei became commander of the IRGC Navy and Hossein Taeb was appointed commander of the paramilitary Basij. But the most significant elevation was that of Mr. Rezaee. He replaced Mohammed Bagher Zolqadri as secretary of the Security Council. Mojtaba's office has also issued a special decree naming him as the representative of the Supreme Leader on the Council, which is today the most important wartime decision-making body on strategic matters.

Born in 1954, Mohsen Rezaee grew up in the Shah's Iran. In the early 1970s, he became active in anti-monarchy protests, and the Shah's infamous

secret police, SAVAK, arrested him in 1973. He later joined the Islamist guerrilla group Mansouroun (The Victors), whose members held the ranks of the IRGC after the Shah's regime fell in 1979. Mr. Rezaee, then 25 years old, sat on the 12-member committee that drafted the IRGC's founding charter. In 1981, a year after Saddam Hussein invaded Iran, Mr. Rezaee was appointed the commander-in-chief of the IRGC, a post he held for 16 years.

Principalist faction

A PhD in economics (his thesis was on the theory of money, credit and general balance), Mr. Rezaee co-founded the Imam Hossein University in Tehran. He had also served as the secretary of the Expediency Discernment Council, a constitutional body tasked with resolving differences between the Guardian Council and the legislature.

Mr. Rezaee has long belonged to the "principalist" faction of Iran's political class – the group broadly

called conservatives. In 2002, when reformist Mohammad Khatami was the President, Mr. Rezaee launched a news site *Baztab* as a conservative platform to counter the reformist agenda.

The 2026 war elevated his position among the top echelons of the Islamic Republic as Mojtaba turned to his longtime loyalists to run the security apparatus. Mr. Rezaee's views about the war, Iran's nuclear programme or its control of the Strait of Hormuz are hardly a secret.

In July, he said the control of the Strait, a critical waterway connecting the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman, was "more important than dozens of atomic bombs". In an interview with CNN in June, he said the "ball is in Trump's court", referring to Iran's demand to release roughly \$24 billion of frozen assets. According to him, U.S. President Donald Trump cannot be trusted in negotiations. He said Iran was prepared for any U.S. ground invasion, which would be "great for us". Uranium enrichment, he once stated, is "an inviolable right" of the Islamic Republic.

The headline insider is today a central figure in Iran's wartime leadership. By elevating Mr. Rezaee to secretary of the Security Council, Mojtaba Khamenei is sending a message that is lost on no one.

Eyes on the seas

UKMTO

What was established to help combat piracy has now emerged as a primary source of information for vessels on the dangers lurking at sea

Debayan Tewari

On August 18, 2026, an unknown projectile hit the Liberia-flagged bulk carrier *Minnoan Dignity* while it was exiting the Strait of Hormuz, killing the ship's chief engineer.

Before the news broke, a 72-word alert had informed seafarers and maritime observers about the attack. It read, "UKMTO has received a report of an incident in the Strait of Hormuz. The Company Security Officer has reported that the vessel was struck by an unknown projectile while conducting an outbound transit of the Strait of Hormuz. The impact caused damage to the engine room and resulted in a crew casualty. The remaining crew are currently being assisted by the Omani Coast Guard. At present, no environmental impact has been reported."

For 25 years now, the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations (UKMTO) has been providing seafarers, shipping companies and authorities "essential, verified and corroborated security information". According to its website, it is a "trusted authority in the maritime security sector, helping protect crucial trade routes". Always working in the background, the West Asia war and Iran's stranglehold over the Strait of Hormuz in the Persian



Gulf, and the threat posed by the Houthis at the Bab el-Mandeb in southern Red Sea, have put this under-the-radar organisation in the spotlight.

Maritime security

The UKMTO is a British Royal Navy-sponsored organisation that was formed in 2001 with an office in Dubai to handle distress calls during piracy threats, particularly near Somalia. In 2014, it was moved to Portsmouth in the U.K. The "UK National Strategy for Maritime Security", presented in the British Parliament in 2014, outlines the U.K.'s broad-based thinking on maritime strategy of which the UKMTO is a part. The document said how "every aspect of our national life" is connected to the wider world and "most of these connections are provided by the sea". Hence, it was seen as an imperative to "organise and use our current national capabilities to identify, assess and address maritime security issues at home and overseas".

For its scale of operations, the UKMTO is a lean organisation with a team of 15 civilian "watch-keepers" and three managers. The team, which works in shifts, takes calls from ship masters irrespective of their nationalities and coordinates rescue responses and issues warnings and advisories.

The UKMTO works in West Asia and the Indian Ocean Region through an information framework agreement and operates a "Voluntary Reporting Scheme within the Voluntary Reporting Area (VRA)" outlined in a maritime security chart, according to its website. This zone stretches to almost 2.5 million sq. miles of the ocean and includes the Red Sea, Arabian Sea, a majority of the northwestern Indian Ocean, Gulf of Aden, Gulf of Oman, and Persian Gulf.

The UKMTO has three 24/7 phone lines and an e-mail to report emergencies or incidents. Ship masters are requested to file multiple reports – an initial report when entering the

VRA, a daily report while transiting the area, and a final report after exiting the VRA or reaching a port. Following an incident, the UKMTO says that a "detailed After Action Report" is submitted.

In June, while reporting on a U.S. attack on a ship in which three Indians were killed off Oman, *The Hindu* had called one of the numbers and sent an email. While the response was prompt, the staff refused to divulge any information about the attack.

Though initially set up to fight piracy and serve British interests, the UKMTO assumed greater significance in November 2023 when Houthis started attacking commercial ships it claimed were linked to Israel or its allies in the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden. Between October and December 2023, after the Hamas attack on Israel and the beginning of the Israeli offensive, the UKMTO "put out 71 warnings and advisories, took part in 40 exercises and drills, handled 27 emergency events," according to the BBC.

Today, the UKMTO has positioned itself as the primary point of contact for commercial vessels with military forces in the region. The reporting system aims to, in the UKMTO's words, "increase security and provide anti-piracy support to maintain the freedom of navigation to all vessels".

World

BUNIA

Congo receives over 16,000 doses of Ebola vaccine amid health crisis



Congo has received more than 16,000 doses of the Ervebo vaccine as the country grapples with the fastest Ebola outbreak in history, the country's Health Minister said. The Ervebo vaccine is licensed to treat Ebola and has been effective in past outbreaks. The WHO said it may provide some protection against the Bundibugyo virus. AP

MOGADISHU

Somali pirates hijack oil products tanker off Yemen in latest attack



Somali pirates hijacked an oil products tanker off Yemen, a Somali maritime security official said, the latest in a resurgence of piracy that has seen six commercial vessels seized since April. Six armed pirates hijacked the Eritrean-flagged M.T. Sibru 1 and took it toward Somalia's Puntland coast, the official said. AP

TORONTO

Two men injured in stabbing at Canada's Edmonton gurdwara



Two men, including a priest, were injured after a 27-year-old man stabbed them with a screwdriver inside a gurdwara in Canada's Edmonton, with police investigating whether the attack was hate-motivated, authorities said. Witnesses detained the suspect until police arrived and arrested him, they added. PTI

LAGOS

Armed men abduct more than 60 worshippers from Nigeria mosque



Armed men abducted over 60 worshippers from a mosque in Nigeria's north-central Niger state during Friday prayers, police said on Saturday, in the latest mass kidnapping in a region plagued by violent gangs. Police said the attackers stormed Kenya Mosque in the Dekara district of the Borgu local government area. REUTERS

U.S. imposes 50% import tariffs on \$20 bn worth of Canadian products

Prime Minister Mark Carney says Canada would match the U.S. tariffs 'dollar for dollar' to protect workers and businesses; while the U.S. side says Canada 'declined to finalise the trade deal, the latter blames 'last-minute changes' in the U.S. proposal

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

The United States imposed 50% tariffs on \$20 billion worth of Canadian products early Saturday, and Canada immediately said it would retaliate after last-ditch negotiations failed to resolve the latest strain in relations between the historic allies.

President Donald Trump's import taxes will hit about 5% of what Canada ships to the United States every year, including products ranging from hockey sticks to tongue depressors.

"Canada will match those tariffs dollar for dol-



Dominic LeBlanc, Canada's Minister in charge of U.S. trade, arrives at the Office of the USTR in Washington DC on Friday. AP

lar to protect our workers and businesses," Prime Minister Mark Carney said in a statement. The retaliation escalates the trade conflict and calls into question the future of a North

American trade agreement covering the United States, Canada and Mexico that is crucial to industry in all three countries.

Canada had sought concessions on tariffs on steel,

aluminum, autos and lumber.

"Tonight, Canada declined to finalise the trade deal under the terms agreed earlier this week. Despite the U.S. offer to Canada to receive the best treatment of any major exporter to our market, new demands and walk-backs of other commitments by Canada have upended the careful balance reached in the past days," U.S. Trade Representative Jameson Greer said in a statement.

Mr. Carney blamed the Republicans administration for the breakdown, saying "last-minute changes in the U.S. proposed terms were unfair, uneconomic, and called into question the re-

liability of any deal". He said he had suspended negotiations and directed Canada's negotiating team to return to Ottawa.

Mr. Carney said his government would announce additional support for Canadian workers and businesses in the coming days.

Mr. Greer said the U.S. offer was "forward-looking" and included "a historic economic and national security partnership".

No further talks are planned.

The breakdown in negotiations marked a sharp reversal from two days earlier, when officials from the two countries sounded as if they were headed toward a compromise.

Russian and Ukrainian strikes kill at least 10 people

Associated Press
KYIV

Russian drone and missile strikes killed at least seven persons in Ukraine, officials said on Saturday, while a Ukrainian drone attack on Russia's Krasnodar region killed three persons there.

The attacks came a day after a Russian strike on a Ukrainian shopping centre killed at least 16 people and wounded some 130.

Moscow's forces have recently intensified their ballistic missile attacks on Kyiv, exploiting Ukraine's chronic shortage of U.S.-made Patriot air defence interceptors, the sole weapon in its arsenal able to shoot down the missiles.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said that one person was killed and another wounded in



Rescuers with a dog work at a site of a shopping centre destroyed in Friday's Russian drone attack in Kryvyi Rih, on Saturday. REUTERS

the latest attacks when ballistic missiles hit railway infrastructure in the capital, Kyiv, overnight.

Russia's Defence Ministry said that its forces had hit a locomotive depot.

Russian drone strikes also killed one person overnight in the Zaporizhzhia region, local officials said on Saturday, and a daytime attack killed three others

and wounded 15. Mr. Zelenskyy said that three persons were also wounded in an attack on a minibus in the regional capital, also called Zaporizhzhia.

In Russia's southern Krasnodar region, authorities said that three people, including two children, were killed and two adults were wounded in a Ukrainian drone strike.

U.S. and Iran keep up their hostile rhetoric ahead of sanctions

Reuters

CAIRO/WASHINGTON

The United States and Iran exchanged defiant messages ahead of Monday's scheduled announcement of new U.S. economic sanctions that could impact the Islamic Republic and Tehran's most important trading partners including China.

Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmaeil Baghaei said on Saturday that the imminent U.S. announcement of new economic

sanctions on Iran was an "assertion of extraterritorial sovereignty over every member state of the United Nations".

"Such secondary sanctions find no foundation in international law," he said in a post on X.

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Friday that Washington was observing "what happens" in the conflict. "They would love to make a deal, but they're not ready to make the right deal, in my opinion."

Imran Khan's sister files contempt plea over violation of SC hospitalisation order

Press Trust of India
ISLAMABAD

The sister of jailed former Pakistan Prime Minister Imran Khan on Saturday filed a petition in the Supreme Court, accusing the government and senior officials of violating the top court's order to shift him to a private hospital for medical examination and treatment.

Uzma Khan has sought contempt proceedings alleging wilful violation of the Supreme Court's August 18 order. The Supreme Court had



Imran Khan's sister, Uzma Khan, speaks as his physician Faisal Sultan watches during a press conference in Islamabad. AP

directed authorities to shift 73-year-old Khan from Adiala Jail in Rawalpindi to Shifa International Hospital in Islamabad within two

days and ordered that he remain there until the next hearing on September 16.

Instead, Mr. Khan was taken to the state-run Pa-

kistan Institute of Medical Sciences (PIMS) in Islamabad during the night of August 20-21 for medical examination and treatment before being returned to Adiala Jail.

Mr. Khan's family and leaders of his political party have termed the move a violation of the SC order and challenged the action.

In her petition, Ms. Uzma Khan urged the top court to initiate contempt proceedings against the respondents for their "wilful, deliberate and contumacious disobedience and violation" of the order.

U.S. federal judge strikes down Trump's 75-country visa ban

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

A U.S. federal judge has struck down a government ban on visas to nationals from 75 countries who wish to settle in the country indefinitely, dealing a blow to President Donald Trump's immigration crackdown.

In a ruling issued on Friday in the Southern District of New York, Judge Jeannette Vargas called the policy "contrary to law" and said Secretary of State

Marco Rubio had exceeded his "statutory authority" in issuing it.

The policy, which came into force in January, suspended the processing of immigrant visas to nationals of 75 countries including Afghanistan, Brazil, Egypt, Iran, Iraq, Nigeria, Somalia, Thailand and Yemen. At that time, the State Department had said the decision was made "to ensure that immigrants from high-risk countries do not unlawfully utilise welfare in the U.S."

Sport

Rohit clinches gold with an impressive show

Y.B. Sarang
BHUBANESWAR

Rohit Yadav spectacularly brushed his personal best to 87.68m to take the men's javelin gold while 19-year-old sprinter Abhinav Rajarajan gave a dazzling performance to clock 11.34s and win the women's 100m with a National under-20 record in the \$75,000 World Athletics Continental Tour Silver meet at the Kalinga Stadium on Saturday.

Vithya Ramraj sparked to record her season's best 51.96 to clinch the women's 400m gold.

In the preparatory phase for next month's Asian Games, long jumpers M. Sreesankar (8.07m) and Ancy Sojan (6.71m) were among the nine Indians who won gold.

Rohit, who managed



Personal best: Rohit's effort of 87.68m ranks fourth in the world this season. BISWARANJAN ROUT

81.56m to finish seventh in the Commonwealth Games, overcame a slip in the second throw to register 81.82m in his penultimate attempt. A more consistent Yashvir logged 82.94m to regain the lead. But, Rohit improved upon his previous best 87.05m, achieved at the Inter-State meet here in June, in his fi-

nal effort. His new mark is the fourth-best in the World this season, just behind Neeraj Chopra (81.05m).

"I gave it my all in the end. I hope to replicate it in the Asian," said Rohit.

Abhinav ran in good rhythm to regain the National under-20 record, which she had held earlier

with 11.54, from Nipam (11.53).

The results: Men: 100m: 1. Tshepo Jason Tyantini (RSA) 10.11, 2. Ali Al Balushi (Oma) 10.16, 3. Dineth Induraya (Sri) 10.27, 6. Animesh Kujur (10.32), 9. Gurinder Singh 10.39, **400m:** 1. Justice Oratile (Bot) 45.35, 2. Leander Koekemoer (RSA) 45.40, 3. Kalinga Hewa Kumara (Sri) 45.61, **800m:** 1. Mofiri Mholomi (RSA) 1:47.45, 2. Krishan Kumar 1:47.69, 3. Prakash Gadade 1:48.03, **5000m:** 1. Harmanjit Singh 14:11.51, 2. Shivaji Parashuram 14:13.84, 3. T. Gopi 14:15.98, **110m hurdles:** 1. Franco Le Roux (RSA) 13.47, 2. Antonio Alkana (RSA) 13.54, 3. Eduardo Rodrigues (Bra) 13.68, **Long jump:** 1. M. Sreesankar 8.07m, 2. Divan Manuel (RSA) 8.03m, 3. David P. 7.78m, **High jump:** 1. Aadash Ram 2.22m, 2. Fatak Baii Jacob (Oma) 2.19m, 3. Abdul Rahman Omar (Iri) 2.15m, **Shot putt:** 1. Chukwuebuka Enekwe (Ngr) 20.78m, 2. Weir Zane (Ita) 20.47m, 3. Karanveer Singh 20.06m, 4.

Tajinderpal Singh 20.03, **Javelin:** 1. Rohit Yadav 87.68m, 2. Yashvir Singh 82.94m, 3. Sumedha Ranasinghe (Sri) 80.29m.

Women: 100m: 1. Abhinav Rajarajan 11.34, 2. Harita Bhadra 11.46, 3. Sneha Sathyanarayan 11.56, **400m:** 1. Vithya Ramraj 51.96, 2. Prachi 52.57, 3. M.R. Poovamma 52.78, **1500m:** 1. Pooja 4:17.24, 2. Lili Das 4:18.32, 3. Shanika Kahawale (Sri) 4:27.22, **5000m:** 1. Diana Wanza (Ken) 15:16.11, 2. Bharti 15:46.45, 3. Santoshi Shrestha (Nep) 17:31.75, **100m hurdles:** 1. Charisma Yarraji 13:24, **Long jump:** 1. Ancy Sojan 6.71m, 2. Shaili Singh 6.56m, 3. Mubassina Mohammed 6.31m, **High jump:** 1. Supriya 1.75m, 2. Manshi 1.75m, 3. Reet Rathi 1.75m, **Discus:** 1. Andressa De Moraes (Bra) 58.66, 2. Samantha Hall (Jam) 58.43, 3. Subenrat Isaeng (Tha) 58.33, **Javelin:** 1. Jucieny Sales De Lima (Bra) 59.13, 2. Dillipa Leikangme (Sri) 58.98m, 3. Annu Rani 56.96m.

Kavyashree stars on a day of upsets

TABLE TENNIS

Amol Karhadkar
KANPUR

Sayali Wani and Taneesha Kotecha, seeded sixth and eighth respectively, suffered early exits while G. Sathiyani and H. Jeho also bowed out at the UTT National-ranking table tennis tournament at The Sportz Hub on Saturday.

On a hectic penultimate day, five of the eight men's main-draw rounds and four of the seven women's rounds were scheduled. Nashik-based Sayali and Taneesha, who represent the Petroleum Sports Promotion Board, fell in the women's round of 64. Jeho and Sathiyani, seeded eighth and 10th respectively, exited in the men's round of 32.

Taneesha went down to

Maharashtra's Pritha Vartika 12-10, 11-13, 11-9, 11-13, 3-11. Tamil Nadu's Kavyashree Baskar stunned Sayali 9-11, 8-11, 11-7, 11-6, 11-7 in a tense battle. Kavyasree later accounted for Bengal's Ahona Ray in another decisive set to enter the last 16.

Sathiyani's Asian Games preparations suffered a setback as the veteran succumbed to IA & AD's south-paw Abhimanyu Mitra in straight games. Jeho, meanwhile, couldn't withstand Priyanju Bhattacharyya's consistency and power, going down in four games.

Top seed Yashaswini Ghorpade survived a scare against Aarti Chaudhary, trailing 4-6 in the decider, Yashaswini reeled off seven points in succession to set up a tantalising pre-quarterfinal clash with top-ranked Sreeja Akula.

Important results (round of

32): Men: Manush Shah (RBI) bt S. Preyesh Raj (RSPB) 16-14, 11-3, 9-11, 11-7; Abhimanyu Mitra (IA&AD) bt G. Sathiyani (PSPB) 12-10, 11-6, 11-8; Divyansh Srivastava (U.P.) bt Sarthak Arya (Od) 5-11, 11-6, 11-2, 11-4; Sanil Shetty (PSPB) bt Ayan Ghosh (Ben) 11-9, 11-6, 11-5; Manav Thakkar (PSPB) bt Neil Mulje (Mah) 11-8, 11-7, 5-11, 11-7; Priyanju Bhattacharyya (RSPB) bt H. Jeho (Miz) 11-3, 7-11, 11-6, 12-10; **Women:** Yashaswini Ghorpade (PSPB) bt Aarti Chaudhary (U.P.) 11-3, 9-11, 11-8, 8-11, 11-6; Sreeja Akula (RBI) bt Anjali Rohilla (IA&AD) 8-11, 11-5, 14-12, 11-8; Syndreela Das (Ben) bt Ayisha Mukherjee (RBI) 11-6, 6-11, 11-8, 11-1; Kavyashree Baskar (TN) bt Ahona Ray (Ben) 11-9, 11-9, 7-11, 3-11, 11-11-9; Anusha Kutumbale (RSPB) bt Hardie Patel (Mah) 8-11, 11-13, 11-11; Swastika Ghosh (PSPB) bt Prithvi Chakraborti (RSPB) 5-11, 11-7, 12-10, 11-8; Suhana Saini (Har) bt Arisha Karmali (PSPB) 11-9, 11-10, 11-7, 10-12, 11-9; Tanishka Kalbhairav (Kar) bt Madhura Patkar (PSPB) 8-11, 12-10, 11-8, 7-11, 11-8.

Sport

PERFECT SCENARIO

Gambhir terms three-Test series format ideal



A three-Test series gives a chance to the team that has lost the first match to make a comeback and win the series. You cannot do that in a two-Test series as the team that lost the first game can only draw the series at best — India head coach Gautam Gambhir ahead of the second and final Test against Sri Lanka.

ONE FOR THE FUTURE

Gambhir praises Suthar for capitalising on the chances



Manav Suthar came in for praise from India coach Gautam Gambhir. "Manav got the big opportunity when he made his Test debut against Afghanistan. This was a big series for him and he put his hand up, which is good for him. He is young and if he keeps working hard, he can take the team forward," Gambhir said.

SIMPLE PLAN

We need to play well from the outset, says Dhananjaya



It's about putting runs on the board. That's what India did (at Galle). We are trying to improve and get some runs and take 20 wickets. We are one down and we are disappointed. Here we need to play well from the outset. Even though we are short on experience, we have a lot of talent — Sri Lanka captain Dhananjaya de Silva.

LEARNING CURVE

'It's been an amazing week, we played some great matches'



They are World No. 1 and we knew they wouldn't give away easy points. But it's been an amazing week, we played some great matches and had a lot to learn from. I think today was just not our day. Towards the second part of the second game, we lost our rhythm and they found theirs — Gayatri Gopichand

'Even if you score 1,000 runs, you still got to get 20 wickets'

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

In his prime as an opener, Gautam Gambhir loved the scent of a battle and drew inspiration from it. The same combative streak lingers in his second avatar as coach.

Speaking to the media at the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground here on Saturday, there was a point in which he was asked about criticism.

The former India star was quick with his riposte: "I am here to win trophies!" Later, he added: "People in the press-box and commentators know that we are going through transition."

Looking ahead to the second Test commencing on Sunday, Gambhir said: "Even if you score 1,000 runs, you still got to get 20 wickets, that's how you win matches. So be it three left-arm spinners or an off-spinner or three seamers, we will take a call on what is the best team suited for this surface, it is about the team and the results."

Praising Devdutt Padikkal and Manav Suthar for their success in the first Test, Gambhir said: "It is encouraging to see them step up and perform straight away and then again we should not judge on just one or two performances. There will be ups and downs and we all know cricket is tough."



It remains to be seen whether off-spinner Saransh replaces Kuldeep in the XI. PTI

Gambhir did not reveal if there would be swap between Kuldeep Yadav and Saransh Jain, but he did tell about his chats with the former: "I want Kuldeep to just try and bowl good spells rather than looking desperate to take a wicket."

Refusing to be drawn in to a discussion over India's chances in the ICC World Test Championship, Gambhir said the immediate focus was on the second game.

Take on fitness issues

And as for players breaking down with injuries, he said: "We had a discussion, we want our best players to play as much cricket as possible."

India holds the aces against a depleted Sri Lanka at SSC

The emphatic win in the opening Test at Galle will stand Gill & Co. in good stead; the host needs big runs to exert scoreboard-pressure on the visiting side in its attempt to square the series

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

From the incandescent natural beauty that Galle offered, Shubman Gill's men have moved to the bustling metropolis that Colombo has always been. This multi-lingual city and a maritime junction both for ancient and modern trade routes, was vital to Ceylon then, and equally critical to Sri Lanka now.

Leading 1-0 and stepping into the second Test commencing at the Sinhalese Sports Club (SSC) Ground here on Sunday, India holds the edge over Sri Lanka. The 165-run triumph at Galle will stand the visitor in good stead, a victory shaped by two young players — Devdutt Padikkal and Manav Suthar.

The pitch was a dull brown on match-even, and fringed by the green outfield and rolled-up covers just in case it rained. Initial purchase for batters and later bonanzas for spinners, are the usual tropes associated with cricketing turfs in the Emerald Isle. And this surface will be no different.

In a batting unit that leant heavily on vice-captain K.L. Rahul and his Karnataka mate Padikkal, it is also time for Yashasvi Jaiswal and Gill to join the party. Dhruv Jurel has done his bit in the middle-order and Rishabh Pant has been his



Big challenge: The Sri Lankan spinners as well as the hot and humid conditions will test Gill. ANI

robust self.

Even if Ravindra Jadeja offers batting solidity in the lower-order, India has a fragile tail, and it leaves the job of scoring runs entirely on the specialist batters. Countering the Sri Lankan spinners under shimmering heat that is intrinsic to the venue, will be a test of patience and technique.

Among the bowlers, Mohammed Siraj remains the spearhead with Prasidh Krishna having effected breakthroughs at Galle. While the spin-department is sorted with Suthar and Jadeja, there could be a swap between Kuldeep Ya-

dav and Saransh Jain in the playing XI. The latter's off-spin could come in handy against left-handed batters.

For Sri Lanka, the fixture offers a chance to draw level in the series. Dinush Chandimal, dealing with a concussion, will be missed in a batting order that is a touch short on experience. But the way Sonal Dinusha batted in the first Test, offered hope. At Galle, in the second innings, he was casually sitting on the side-wall, soaking in the sun, and awaiting his turn to bat.

Dinusha's senior colleagues have to contribute

as Sri Lanka needs big runs to exert scoreboard-pressure on India. A Test debut for Kamil Mishara is on the cards. The southpaw blitzed an unbeaten 145 in a recent domestic T20, but against India and in a Test, he would have to temper that innate aggression with caution.

The bulk of the home attack will lean on spinners Prabhath Jayasuriya and Keshara Nuwantha. Their interrogation of the Indian batters would be the key that would determine how this game will proceed.

Gill's men have ticked most of the boxes on this tour. They landed early, had a warm-up game, pocketed the Test at Galle, and in their last week in Sri Lanka, would want to retain the feel-good factor. Sri Lanka, though, will be keen on an ambush.

The teams (from): Sri Lanka:

Dhananjaya de Silva (Capt.), Lahiru Udara, Kamil Mishara, Pasindu Sooriyabandara, Kamindu Mendis, Sahana Arachchige, Sonal Dinusha, Niroshan Dickwell (wk), Keshara Nuwantha, Prabhath Jayasuriya, Milan Rathnayake, Lahiru Kumara, Asitha Fernando and Vishwa Fernando.

India: Shubman Gill (Capt.), K.L.

Rahul (Vice-capt.), Yashasvi Jaiswal, Devdutt Padikkal, Rishabh Pant (wk), Dhruv Jurel, Sarfaraz Khan, Ravindra Jadeja, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Jugesh Patel, Gurnoor Brar, Kuldeep Yadav, Manav Suthar and Saransh Jain.

Match starts at 10 a.m.

Pujara backs Padikkal to do well at No. 3

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

Former India batter Cheteshwar Pujara backed Devdutt Padikkal at the crucial No. 3 spot in Test cricket, but added that his long-term prospects depend on tougher challenges that lie ahead.

Padikkal's red-ball stock took an upturn after the southpaw struck a fine 167 in the first Test against Sri Lanka. "Devdutt has been outstanding. He got the opportunity because unfortunately Sai (Sudharshan) was not fit," Pujara said during a virtual media interaction on Saturday.

"But Devdutt was ready — the way he has been performing in the domestic circuit and IPL, we have seen that he has worked on his game and improved his technique."

Pujara added that Sai Sudharshan should be accommodated in the team when fit. "India should go ahead with Devdutt at No. 3

for some time, but you cannot leave someone like Sai Sudharshan out of India's Test squad. I am not saying that he should be batting at three, but he should be there in the scheme of things." The real test for Padikkal will come when India faces New Zealand (away) and Australia (in India) in the next six months. "If Devdutt performs consistently in both those series, then he will cement his spot."

The 38-year-old called on the team management to rally behind spinner Kuldeep Yadav, who was not among the wickets at Galle.

"I hope the team management and captain show a little more faith on him. If you are a third spinner, you are bound to have moments where you are not picking up wickets because you are not getting too many overs," said Pujara.

(Watch Sri Lanka vs. India second Test live on Sony Sports Ten 2 SD & HD and Sony LIV from 10 a.m. on August 23).

Australia gets lead as 18 wickets fall on day one

Agence France-Presse
MACKAY

Australia scratched out a 101-run lead over Bangladesh on Saturday in the second Test, with 18 wickets falling on day one after Mitchell Starc and Shoriful Islam both took six in a fast-bowling masterclass.

The Aussies skittled out Bangladesh for 64 with

Starc taking five wickets in 22 balls during the morning session.

Australia stumbled to 165 for eight at stumps with Cameron Green standing tall on 51 alongside Nathan Lyon (10).

The scores: Bangladesh 64 in 34 overs (Starc 1/2, Cummins 3/25) vs. Australia 165/8 in 40 overs (Smith 42, Green 51 batting, Shoriful 6/35; Toss: Australia).



Upset alert: Newly promoted Hull stunned United. GETTY IMAGES

Arsenal up and running; Manchester United stalls

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Arsenal made the perfect start to its Premier League title defence with a stylish 3-0 win against Coventry in the opening game of the season on Friday.

Kai Havertz struck early in the first half and Bukayo Saka doubled the lead before Martin Odegaard netted after the interval to complete Arsenal's win.

Manchester United crashed to a humiliating 2-0 defeat at promoted Hull on Saturday in a dismal start to its campaign.

Michael Carrick's side

was rocked by first half goals from Semi Ajayi and Nobel Mendy.

The results: Premier League: Hull 2 (Ajayi 17, Mendy 38) bt Manchester United 0; Everton 2 (Dewsbury-Hall 42, Barry 53) bt Crystal Palace 0; Ipswich 2 (Emerson 24, Clarke 50) bt Sunderland 1 (Angulo 39); Nottingham Forest 0 lost to Leeds 1 (Stach 88); Brentford 3 (Lewis-Potter 12, Janelt 33, Kayode 49) bt Tottenham 0.

Serie A: Inter Milan 4 (Calhanoglu 6, Zielinski 48, Esposito 55, Bisseck 63) bt Monza 1 (Varela 29); Udinese 1 (Kamara 29) drew with Como 1 (Douvikas 54).

On Friday: Premier League: Arsenal 3 (Havertz 15, Saka 23, Odegaard 49) bt Coventry 0.

La Liga: Real Betis 1 (Riquelme 63) bt Real Sociedad 0.

Treesa and Gayatri's winning streak ends

BADMINTON WORLDS

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

It was a dream run that had to end at some point. Giant-killers Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand finally ran out of steam in the semifinals of the badminton World championships. They went down fighting to China's Sheng Shu Liu and Ning Tan 18-21, 21-13, 21-8 here on Saturday.

It was a match that started with the Chinese firm favourites. It saw the players and fans go through a roller-coaster of fortunes and emotions but eventually the top-seeds, reigning World champions and runners-up at the Paris Olympics two years ago, advanced to the final.

The Indians, already assured of a medal, lost but were not discredited. If anything, the performance only burnished their growing reputation as serious challengers. Starting slow, Treesa and Gayatri relied more on skills and smart play than raw power to



Ebb and flow: After losing the first and taking the second, Sheng and Ning were unstoppable in the decider. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

race to a 7-2 lead before Sheng and Ning reiterated why they are so feared on the court.

The Chinese reeled off 10 consecutive points to go 12-7 up. It looked like it would be yet another straight game win for them before Treesa and Gayatri changed their tactics.

The Indians had played a different game to their previous outings so far, relying more on cross-court volleys and soft drops at the net instead. But now

the jump smashes that had been conserved came out, they began attacking more and picked up six points to go 13-12 up. Things stayed close before Liu dropped her service short at 16-18 that became 21-18 in favour of the home pair.

It was the first game the Chinese duo had dropped in the tournament.

The second game, too, stayed close till 12-12 before Sheng and Ning took off eight points to clinch it 21-13 and then raced away

with the decider.

Korea's Baek Ha Na and Lee So Hee beat Li Yi Jing and Luo Xu Min 21-17, 21-12 in the other semifinal.

Meanwhile, Akane Yamaguchi will face An Se-young for her title defence. Alex Lanier became the first Frenchman ever to reach the title clash of the marquee event and will take on Kodai Naraoka.

The results (semifinals): Men:

Alex Lanier (Fra) bt Victor Lai (Can) 16-21, 21-13, 21-14; Kodai Naraoka (Jpn) bt Chou Tien Chen (Tpe) 17-21, 21-11, 21-10.

Doubles: Aaron Chia & Soh Wooi Yik (Mas) bt Kim Won Ho & Seo Seung Jae (Kor) 21-17, 21-18; Liang Wei Keng & Wang Chang (Chn) bt Lee Jhe-Huei & Yang Po-Hsuan (Tpe) 21-18, 21-14.

Women: Akane Yamaguchi (Jpn) bt Pornpawee Chochuwong (Tha) 21-12, 21-17, 21-12; An Se-young (Kor) bt Wang Zhiyi (Chn) 24-22, 21-16.

Doubles: Baek Ha Na & Lee So Hee (Kor) bt Li Yi Jing & Luo Xu Min (Chn) 21-17, 21-12; Sheng Shu Liu & Ning Tan (Chn) bt Treesa Jolly & Gayatri Gopichand 18-21, 21-13, 21-8.

Mixed doubles: Feng Yan Zhe & Huang Dong Ping (Chn) bt Amri Syahmawati & Nita Violina Marwah (Ind) 20-22, 21-14, 22-20; Thong Gietzel & Delphine Delrue (Fra) bt Jiang Zheng Bang & Wei Ya Xin (Chn) 19-21, 21-13, 21-11.

Battle lines drawn for singles coronation

Devvanshi Bihani
NEW DELHI

The men's singles final will crown a new badminton World champion. The women's title clash will pit the defending champion against a three-time victor.

In men's singles, 21-year-old Alex Lanier will face Japan's Kodai Naraoka for a world title neither has won before, with both guaranteed their first World championships medal.

Lanier beat Canada's Victor Lai 16-21, 21-13, 21-14. "At some point you need to trust how good you are," Lanier said. Naraoka lost the opening game 17-21 to veteran Chou Tien Chen before winning the next two 21-11, 21-10. Chou, 36, has been chasing a second record after becoming the oldest men's singles medalist in World championships history, but Naraoka's patience and rallying eventually ended that bid.

The women's final brings together An Se-young and Akane Yamaguchi, with Se-young holding a 19-15 advantage. Yamagu-



Se-young. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

chi moved through with a composed 21-12, 21-17 victory over Thailand's Pornpawee Chochuwong, becoming the only women's singles player to win six World championships medals.

Se-young survived a gruelling opening game against Wang Zhi Yi. She appeared to struggle with her left leg late in the second set, but stayed in the contest and sealed victory with a net dribble at 20-16.

The Japanese star now stands between Se-young and a second straight title. "I'm looking forward to how I perform," said Se-young.

INBRIEF



Neeraj's season best not enough to beat Pathiraje

Indian javelin ace Neeraj Chopra produced his best performance in more than a year but was pipped to the top spot by rising Sri Lankan star Ramesh Pathiraje by a mere 9cm in the Lausanne Diamond League meet on Friday. Neeraj's 88.05m throw in the second round fetched him the second spot in the nine-man star-studded field. However, the 23-year-old Pathiraje overtook Neeraj with his third-round throw of 88.14m. Grenada's Anderson Peters was third with his final round effort of 86.69m.



Saishiva, Gyan score thrilling wins in MRF Formula races

S. Gyan and Saishiva Sankaran scored dramatic victories in the Formula 1600 and Formula 2000 categories, respectively, on the opening day of the MRF Indian National Racing Challenge 4W in Chennai on Saturday.

Provisional results (all 10 laps unless mentioned): MRF F2000 (Race-1, 9 laps): 1. Saishiva Sankaran 14:47.457s; 2. Aditya Patnaik 14:48.121s; 3. Swarnav Das 14:53.134. **MRF F1600 (Race-1, 9 laps):** 1. S. Gyan 16:28.952s; 2. Priyanka Vijay 14:52.355s; 1 lap; 3. Bhuvan Bonu 14:59.959s; 1 lap. **Formula LGB 1300 (Race-1) Open:** 1. Viswas Vijayaraj (DTS Racing) 18:53.431s; 2. Vinithkumar (DTS Racing) 18:58.267s; 3. Liron Jaden Samuels 19:03.051. **Junior:** 1. Kaveen Diyyan Rajapaksa (Momentum Motorsports) 19:21.510s; 2. Abhishek Vadavalli (Momentum Motorsports) 19:39.205s; 3. Yash Vikram Singh (Delta Speeds) 19:39.596s.



Jockey Suraj makes India proud in Japan

Jockey Suraj Narreddu made India proud as he added yet another glorious chapter to his illustrious career by registering his first Japan Racing Association (JRA) victory at the Sapporo Racecourse in Japan on Saturday, August 22. In his first appearance on Japanese soil, Suraj partnered Fier Chanter trained by Kensuke Ogura, to victory in the 2,600m race for three-year-old maidens, producing a memorable triumph on the opening day of his historic stint in Japan. Suraj had earlier finished fourth aboard Mont Royal in the third race (1,700m), his maiden event. He then celebrated his landmark JRA success when Fier Chanter scored in the sixth race.

Hyderabad Race Club elections held at its 55th AGM

The 55th Annual General Meeting of the Hyderabad Race Club (HRC) was held in Hyderabad on Saturday (Aug. 22) evening. Mr. Raghuram Reddy Ramasamyiah, Mr. Manish Jaiswal, Mr. Krishna Rama Mohan Rao Veeramachaneni (V. Krishna Mohan) and Mr. Seshadri Reddy Pochana (P.S. Reddy) were elected as the Stewards of HRC.

LIVE TELECAST

Duleep Trophy: Quarterfinals, Day 1, JioHottar, 9.30 a.m.
Sri Lanka vs India: Second Test, Day 1, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10 a.m.
Badminton: World Championships, Sports 18-1, 3, JioHottar & BWF Official YouTube channel, 1 p.m.
Hockey World Cup: (Women): SS Select 2, Star Sports First & JioHottar, 1.30 p.m. 4.30, 7.30 & Australia vs India: 10.30 p.m. (Men): SS Select 2, Star Sports First & JioHottar, 3 p.m., 6 p.m. & 12 a.m. (Monday)
Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 5 p.m.
Premier League: SS Select 1 & JioHottar, 6.30 a.m. & 9 p.m.
Formula One: Dutch GP, F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 6.30 p.m.
TNPL: Sony Sports Ten 4 Tamil & TNPL Official YouTube channel (youtube@tamilnadupremierleague.com), 7.30 p.m.
LaLiga: FanCode, 8.30, 11 p.m. & 1 a.m. (Monday)
Serie A: Unitel Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 10 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Monday)

Dutch enter semis; India on the brink of elimination

The home side punishes Harmanpreet & Co. on the counter; the former champion is languishing at the bottom of Pool E but has a slim hope, thanks to Argentina's 3-1 victory over England

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

India got a close up display on how to come up with a clinical performance at the hands of the Netherlands.

With six minutes to go, Manpreet Singh dawdled on the ball allowing Jorrit Croon to rob the ball and slip in Thijs van Dam. The forward flicked it over Mothi H.S., controlled it on the run, before slapping the ball into the net to finish off India in style.

In front of a packed Wagener Stadion, Netherlands sealed its place in the semifinal of the World Cup with a 3-1 win, pushing India to the brink of elimination here on Saturday. Argentina got the better of England 3-1 later in the day to boost its qualification chances.

Placed last, India needs to defeat Argentina by a margin of four goals or more in its final Pool E match on Monday and hope that the Dutch defeat England on the same day.

Requiring a win, India put up a spirited fight, but familiar troubles in field play plagued Craig Fulton's



Keen tussle: Rajinder and de Velder fight for possession. GETTY IMAGES

men. But the Dutch, picked apart India with three field goals, two of them coming from devastating counter-attacks.

Of the four matches in the tournament, this was India's best start. Fulton's side was sharper on the ball, controlling possession, not allowing the Dutch to play their flick passing game.

However, India, too, didn't find space in the circle, struggling to find the right connections in field play.

After trading blows

again in the third quarter, the Dutch found momentum, before taking the lead. From a loose ball in the circle, Tijmen Rayenga's shot-cum-pass was flicked in past Suraj Karkeera by Dago Telgenkamp.

Chasing the equaliser, Harmanpreet Singh and Sanjay were exchanging passes at the halfway line before the latter tried to force the initiative with a fizzed-in pass went out of bounds.

Seconds later, the Netherlands turned defence into attack with three passes.

Tijp Hoedemakers deflected the ball into the goal from a fierce Koen Bijen slapshot into the circle.

India responded immediately through Harmanpreet, finding the left bottom corner with his side's sixth and final PC to halve the deficit.

But India's hopes of a comeback were extinguished when Manpreet's error was punished by van Dam.

The result: Netherlands 3 (Telgenkamp 40, Hoedemakers 50, van Dam 54) bt India 1 (Harmanpreet 51-pc).

Strikers women notch up second straight win

DPL

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

North Delhi Strikers rode on Shivi Sharma's unbeaten 71 and a disciplined bowling effort to clinch a 10-run win over South Delhi Superstars. In the women's section of the Delhi Premier League at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Saturday.

Strikers' second straight victory puts them on top of the points table.

Batting first, Strikers made 141 for four, with Upasana Yadav and Shivi playing leading roles.

The opening batters stitched together a partnership of 84 in 12.3 overs, setting the base for a competitive total. While Upasana made 43, Shivi stayed unbeaten on 71 off 54 deliveries.

In response, Superstars were dealt an early setback when Nishika Singh fell for a duck in the opening over. None of the other Super-



Moment of joy: North Delhi Strikers women celebrate a wicket. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

starz batters were able to produce an impactful knock, allowing the North Delhi bowlers to apply the squeeze on the scoring rate. Nazma took two wickets for Strikers.

Kings dominant

A power-packed batting performance helped Central Delhi Kings beat West Delhi Lions by 21 runs in the men's tournament on Saturday. After amassing 232 for eight, Central Delhi, which has already qualified for the playoffs, restricted the Nitish Rana-led

side to 211 for eight for its ninth win in 10 matches.

The scores: Women: North Delhi Strikers women 141/4 in 20 overs (Upasana Yadav 43, Shivi Sharma 71 n.o., Roopali Mohan 2/25, Disha Nagar 2/20) bt South Delhi Superstars women 131/5 in 20 overs (Tanishqa Singh 46, Nazma 2/28).

Men: Central Delhi Kings 232/8 in 20 overs (Samarth Singh 37, Siddharth Jeon 33, Money Grewal 42, Shubham Dubey 2/49, Manan Bhardwaj 3/37, Mayank Gussain 2/48) bt West Delhi Lions 211/8 in 20 overs (Krish Yadav 46, Nitish Rana 31, Ankit Kumar 61, Money Grewal 2/54, Keshav Dabas 2/38, Tejas Baroka 2/28).

Russell clinches Dutch GP sprint race

Agence France-Presse
ZANDVOORT

Mercedes driver George Russell powered to victory in the Dutch Grand Prix sprint race on Saturday.

Lando Norris took pole for Sunday's race, pipping Russell and Kimi Antonelli.

The starting grid: First row: Lando Norris (McLaren) and George Russell (Mercedes); Second: Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes) and Oscar Piastri (McLaren); Third: Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari) and Charles Leclerc (Ferrari); Fourth: Max Verstappen (Red Bull Racing) and Liam Lawson (Red Bull Racing); Fifth: Gabriel Bortoleto (Audi) and Avard Lindblad (Racing Bulls); Sixth: Pierre Gasly (Alpine) and Yuki Tsunoda (Racing Bulls);



Russell, AFP

Seventh: Nico Hulkenberg (Audi) and Franco Colapinto (Alpine); **Eighth:** Esteban Ocon (Haas F1 Team) and Alexander Albon (Williams); **Ninth:** Carlos Sainz (Williams) and Fernando Alonso (Aston Martin); **Tenth:** Lance Stroll (Aston Martin) and Oliver Bearman (Haas F1 Team); **11th:** Valtteri Bottas (Cadillac) and Sergio Perez (Cadillac).

Back to full fitness, Mayank savours the start of a new journey

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

Pace is Mayank Yadav's foremost ally.

That was established in the blink of an eye in the 2024 Indian Premier League (IPL), where he went on to clock a top speed of 156.7 kmph for Lucknow Super Giants. With such a gift in his locker, he was predictably fast-tracked into the T20I set-up for a three-match series against Bangladesh in October that year.

While he equipped himself well to the challenge by picking four wickets at an economy rate of 6.91, a spate of injuries cast a shadow over the next 18 months.

Most worryingly, a stress fracture in the back – a chink in the armour for most young speedsters – forced Mayank to undergo surgery and miss vast chunks of the cricketing calendar.

The upside is that the 24-year-old is now back to full fitness.

On his comeback for In-



It's lights out time for domestic cricket

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

Duleep Trophy was once an important pit stop in a cricketer's journey towards the Indian National team.

But now, with the mushrooming of glitzy and faster highways to success like the IPL and India-A, the inter-zonal competition has slid down the importance chart. It is not that the Duleep Trophy is irrelevant; a good performance against the best Ranji Trophy players from the previous season still carries significant value. But it is just one more data point in a cricketer's graph and not the clincher it once was.

Yet, when the 2026-27 edition starts on Sunday at the BCCI Centre of Excel-

lence here, there will be sufficient interest.

In the inaugural round, the competitive match – at least on paper – is expected to be the North Zone-West Zone encounter.

But Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's presence on the adjacent ground, turning out for East versus the North East, will attract enough eyeballs. North will be led by Jammu & Kashmir's Kanhaiya Wadhawan, and has six of his Statesmates, a hat-trick to J & K's maiden Ranji triumph. Ruturaj Gaikwad will marshal West Zone's resources.

Defending champion Central and runner-up South have been given bites to the semifinals. The next four days will decide who they will face.



Mayank, AP

dia in a T20I series against Zimbabwe last month, he picked a wicket off his very first ball.

He finished with five scalps in the series as the

Men in Blue completed a clean sweep. "To take a wicket off my first ball (against Zimbabwe) was a special feeling since I was returning after (almost) two years," Mayank told the media on Friday.

"It feels like my run of injuries is over. This is like the start of a new journey."

In the ongoing Delhi Premier League, Mayank has built on his workload by featuring in six of East Delhi Riders' eight games. He has claimed seven wickets at an average of 21.57.

"I'm feeling 100% fit. I came to play in the DPL after the Zimbabwe tour because I wanted a lot of game-time," Mayank said.

During his time on the sidelines, the desire to wear the India jersey again helped the fast bowler retain a positive outlook.

"I played a lot of games on PlayStation when I was in rehab. It was a good pastime," he revealed.

"Mentally, to be in a good space, I was working towards the aim of representing the country again."

Timeless Vision should score over her rivals

HYDERABAD: The five-year-old mare Timeless Vision should score over her rivals in the Governor's Trophy, the main event of Sunday's (Aug. 23) races.

1. HIDDEN BLOOM PLATE (Div. I) (1,400m), 3y-o and upward, rated 60 to 85 (Cat. II), 1.20 p.m.: 1. Sugar (7) Ashad Ashar 60, 2. Siddharth Jeon 58, 3. Decoy (9) Mukesh K 57, 4. Calista Girl (8) Imran Chisty 56, 5. Romantic Grey (6) Afroz K 53.5, 6. Lucky Zone (4) Kuldeep Jr. 53, 7. Corinthian (5) Akshay K 52.5, 8. Dali's Destiny (2) Gaurav 52.5, 9. Glorious Power (1) M.S. Deora 52.5.

1. CERTINANTH, 2. DALI'S DESTINY, 3. DECOY

1. FRENCH LIEUTENANT, 2. NOX TUBER, 3. PROHERS

3. HUSSAIN SAGAR TROPHY (1,600m), 3y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 2.30 p.m.: 1. Pride Aside (5) Imran Chisty 62, 2. Fly Tote Stars (3) Kuldeep Jr. 61, 3. Bartolino (7) A.A. Vikrant 59, 4. Real Thalavala (2) D.S. Deora 58, 5. Quintessential (1) P. Ajesh K 56.5, 6. Hoping High (6) Mohit 52.5 and 7. Moonlite Rose (4) Surya Prakash 51.5.

1. HOPING HIGH, 2. PRIDE ASIDE, 3. BARTOLINO

4. HIDDEN BLOOM PLATE (Div. II) (1,400m), 3y-o and upward, rated 60 to 85 (Cat. II) (No Whips), 3.05 p.m.: 1. Certainty (3) T.S. Jodha 60, 2. Walking Thunder (6) P. Ajesh K 59.5, 3. Victoria Doreasani (7) Akshay K 58.5, 4. She Can (5) Md. Ismail 58, 5. Annihilator (1) Mukesh K 56, 6. Knight Crusader (8) B.R. Kumar 56, 7. Born Brave (4) B. Nikhil 55.5 and 8. Noble Heart (2) Shivam 54.5.

1. CERTINANTH, 2. VICTORIA DOREASANI, 3. KNIGHT CRUSADER

5. RED RUM PLATE (1,000m) (Terms) Maiden, 3y-o only (Cat. II), 3.40 p.m.: 1. Ashwa Vivegam (3) Gaurav 54.5, 2. Sporting Touch (1) M.S. Deora 56, 3. Svalpavitra-

sakthi (10) Santosh Raj 56, 4. Vidy-utprabha (6) Ajay K 56, 5. Zorba (4) P. Ajesh K 56, 6. Anamara (11) Akshay K 54.5, 7. Calista Babe (7) A.A. Vikrant 54.5, 8. First Kiss (10) S. Chirah The Lady (12) Ajay K 54, 11. Char Ek Char (6) Santosh Raj 50.5 and 12. Screenshot (4) Arjun 50.

1. SUREALIST, 2. HANUMANMAHARAJA, 3. RED HOT PUNCH

8. KARINMAGAR PLATE (1,400m) Maiden, 3y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 5.20 p.m.: 1. Dream To Fly (8) G. Naresh 60, 2. La Quinta (2) P. Sai K 60, 3. Lion's Gate (9) Ajay K 57.5, 4. Dittine Faith (10) B.R. Kumar 56.5, 5. Valledonna (7) P. Ajesh K 56.5, 6. Zindabad (3) Mukesh K 56, 7. Dino (6) Akshay K 55, 8. December Caspian (4) Mohit 54.5, 9. Vedanta (11) Kuldeep Jr. 53.5, 10. Don Cherie (1) B. Nikhil 52.5, 11. See My Attitude (5) Surya Prakash 52.5, and 12. Sugriva (12) Arjun 52.5.

1. DINO, 2. LION'S GATE, 3. DREAM TO FLY

Day's Best: DINO

Jackpot: 4, 5, 6, 7 & 8

Mini Jackpot: 1, 2, 3, 4 & 5, (ii) 5, 6, 7 & 8

Trifecta: (i) 1, 2 & 3, (ii) 3, 4 & 5, (iii) 5, 6, 7 & 8

Tanale All races.

M N DICE



Corroded health: A villager shows his damaged nails, attributing it to heavy metal contamination in groundwater.



Stagnant hazard: Yellowish-green water in a trough near Chhiwali village in Uttar Pradesh's Fatehpur district.



Neighbourhood watch: A warning sign on toxic waste pileup painted on a wall near Asifpur-Abhaypur village in Fatehpur.



A trail of slime: Chemical sludge seen at an open dump in Fatehpur district. Dumping of hazardous basic chromium sulphate over the years has eroded soil cover in many areas.

Toxic water runs deep

Unchecked industrial waste pileup has affected at least three villages in Uttar Pradesh, where yellow-coloured groundwater and patches of yellow-green top soil — indicators of chromium contamination — has been reported in several areas



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Decades of improper industrial waste management have contaminated groundwater with toxic hexavalent chromium across parts of three districts of Uttar Pradesh, exposing villagers to unsafe water and serious health risks.

Groundwater from handpumps glows bright yellow in different villages of these districts — a telltale sign of toxic hexavalent chromium contamination. Patches of yellow-green earth can also be seen in villages across these districts, revealing the illegal dumps and toxicity hiding beneath the surface.

The dumping started from 1976, as per the National Green Tribunal (NGT). But it was scattered and in different districts at different points of time.

The earliest, largest chromium dump came up around 1976 in Rania, Kanpur Dehat, say NGT reports. There were 62,225 metric tonnes of chromium waste dumped there. It was removed only about a year ago, following NGT orders and

missed deadlines. There is an NGT direction to erect a boundary wall around it to minimise the dust from flying out, but the hazards remain.

Over the last five years, the government collected blood samples of people living in the affected areas. It was found that 73%-96% of the samples had levels of hexavalent chromium above safe limits, according to a 2025 government report. But despite years of complaints and legal intervention, the government's efforts to identify contaminated areas, provide safe drinking water and healthcare, and clean up toxic waste remain slow and inadequate.

Sadly, many villages with contaminated groundwater or chemical dumps are not even part of the State government's list of identified chromium-affected areas, indicating that the actual affected area is even larger than what the government has accepted so far and thousands more people could be at risk.

Text by Nikhil M. Babu



Sad plight: A woman seen using a handpump to draw what seems to be water loaded with highly toxic hexavalent chromium at Shivnathpura village in Akbarpur tehsil of Kanpur Dehat district.



Deep rot: Yellowish marks representing heavy metal contamination seen beneath the road surface near a bridge near Chhiwali village at Fatehpur district.



Lethal legacy: The site of one of the oldest and largest chromium dumps at Rania in Kanpur Dehat district. The surface discolouration bears witness to the chromium waste previously here.



Growing risk: The Ganga flows not very far from the villages that are suffering from chromium contamination. Many villages with contaminated groundwater or chemical dumps are not even part of the State government's list of affected areas.



Lurking beneath: A view of a well dumped with waste. Despite years of complaints and legal intervention, the government's efforts to identify contaminated areas remain inadequate.



Tainted tap: Discoloured water from a handpump near Chhiwali village in Fatehpur district. According to a 2025 government report, 73% to 96% of blood samples from villagers showed high chromium levels.